

“ENGLISH PAPER 1: POETRY

In book 9 of the 1674 version of Milton’s biblical epic ...

CRITICS

- Tetrachordon: “men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law”
- “Satan, who soliloquises, may be thought of as choosing to be a Jacobean villain-hero” – Alistair Fowler
- “[Milton had] the power of displaying the vast, illuminating the awful, darkening the gloomy, and aggravating the dreadful” – Edmund Burke
- “[Narrator] interjections and caveats draw attention to the arbitrary nature (and so ineffectiveness) of human language when faced with the task of expressing divinity” – Liam Haydon
- “[paradise lost’s] high action and amazing natural world can also be viewed ... as gloriously heroic” – Alistair fowler
- “If one is left at the end in any doubt as to God’s justice and love, the poem has failed” – Alistair fowler
- “Not simply tragedy” – Alistair fowler
- “Readers must finally decide for themselves whether Milton satanises the epic or measures Satan against an epic standard and finds him wanting” – John Leonard
- William Empson – “however wicked Satan’s plan may be, it is God’s plan too” “The reason why the poem is so good is that it makes God so bad”
- “This wavering, slumbering, deceptive state of consciousness is another factor that gives Satan fictional depth, concealing him from our full knowledge” - John Carey
- “Nothing can exceed the energy and magnificence of the character of Satan as expressed in Paradise Lost” – Percy Shelley
- “If [Eve’s] failure is to have meaning, we must grant with our whole hearts that she possessed the capacity for success” – Stella Revard
- Eve falls because “like [Satan], she is secretly dissatisfied with her place, secretly preoccupied with questions of ‘equality’” – Gilbert and Gubar

- “The fall occurs when reason, stronger in the person of Adam, relinquishes its sovereignty over judgement ... to passion, which is stronger in the person of Eve. Eve’s weaker reason falls victim ...” – Fredson Bowers
 - “[Milton] serenely proposes to justify the ways of God to men, calls upon subservient female muses for the assistance that is his due (and in real life upon slavish daughters for the same sort of assistance), and at the same time wars upon women with a barrage of angry words” – Gilbert and Gubar
 - Marcia Landy: Milton is committed to “The centrality of marriage, to the designated roles of the man as creator and provider and of women as procreator, submissive to her husband’s natural authority”
 - “Milton’s portrayal of Eve stands in radiant contrast to the sly or naïve temptress who bore her name previous to the writing of Paradise Lost” – Diane McColley
 - “Her prelapsarian actions ... are not foreshadowings of necessary sin, but illustrations of actual and potential virtue ... a fall is always possible but never inevitable” – Diane McColley
 - “Milton, in contrast to Adam, illuminates strengths in Eve” – Mike Edward (“Domestick Adam” vs “Adventurous Eve”)
 - “Milton would’ve seen the active involvement of powerful wives in the English civil war ... these women defied cultural expectations” – Shannon Miller
 - “Eve is in significant respect an equal, a companion for Adam with considerable powers of reasoning” – Matthew Jordan
 - “By no means the hollow temptress” – Matthew Jordan
 - “The goodness, happiness, and dignity of every being consists in obeying its natural superior and ruling its natural inferiors” – C.S Lewis
-

CONTEXT:

Genesis

- Genesis gives action; Milton gives motive
- Eve does not simply eat: she reasons, debates, desires, questions, and rationalises
- Milton humanises the fall: sin becomes not just an inherited doctrine but a recognisable human process

Renaissance tragedy

- Renaissance tragedy often focuses on a high-born protagonist whose inner flaw leads to catastrophe

- Eve's "Rash hand" and Adam being "Fondly overcome" can be read as tragic flaws
- "Good lost and evil got" resemble tragic recognition

Nemesis

- Refers to punishment or downfall that follows arrogance, overreaching or moral imbalance
- Satan seeks revenge, but admits it "back on itself recoiles"
- Eve seeks equality or superiority but loses innocence and harmony
- Adam seeks unity with Eve but loses god
- Milton presents ambition and pride as self-punishing. The pursuit of power creates its own collapse

National Epic

- Milton wanted to write an English Christian Epic that likely focused on British history or Arthurian legends, that could rival Virgil or Homer
- Instead of celebrating England, he makes the Fall of humanity his epic subject: Book 9 turns inward moral choice into epic action. The real battlefield is human will

Homer

- Homeric epic glorifies war, heroes, journeys and martial fame. Milton invokes this tradition but revises it. He redefines what makes something heroic or epic
- True heroism becomes reason, obedience, self-control and moral endurance

Virgil

- Like Virgil, Milton writes about origins. But instead of explaining Rome, he takes the far wider task of explaining humanity's fallen condition
- Milton borrows epic scale but redirects it towards Christian salvation history

English Civil War

- Milton lived through the English Civil War, the execution of Charles I, the Commonwealth and the Restoration.

- Book 9's concern with freedom and obedience reflects political anxiety its.
- Eve and Adam's debates can be read through civil-war debates about legitimate power

Oliver Cromwell

- Milton supported the republican cause associated with Cromwell, though he later experienced the disappointment of the restoration
- Satan's republican-style rhetoric is disturbing because Milton valued liberty and eloquence, yet shows how persuasive speech can become manipulative and tyrannical

Petrarch

- Petrarchan love idealises the beloved woman, often making her seem spiritually elevated or almost divine
- Adam's garland for Eve and his intense idealisation of her can be read through this tradition
- Milton critiques excessive romantic idealisation. Adam's love becomes idolatrous when Eve replaces God as his highest good.

The Renaissance

- Valued classical learning, individual dignity, eloquence, beauty, and intellectual ambition
- Milton draws heavily on classical mythology, epic conventions, and humanist rhetoric
- Book 9 uses Renaissance values but also tests them knowledge, eloquence and ambition can elevate humanity but they can also lead to pride and sin

Humanism

- Humanism emphasised education, rhetoric, classical texts and moral reasoning. Satan's comparison to an orator directly evokes humanist admiration for classical eloquence

Litterarum lumen

- "The light of learning" – represents the Renaissance belief that literature and education illuminate human understanding
- Book 9 complicates this optimism: Satan's rhetoric shows that knowledge and learning without moral obedience can become corrupt

Profusions

- Renaissance style often delights in abundance: rich imagery, elaborate description and sensory excess
- Eden is described through profuse colour, scent, fertility and beauty
- Edenic abundance is beautiful, but it also tests restraint
- Profusion can become temptation when delight turns into appetite

The Reformation

- The reformation emphasised scripture, conscience, individual faith and direct responsibility before God
- Adam and Eve cannot simply obey mechanically. They must choose obedience freely

The Counter-Reformation

Puritanism

- Milton shared many puritan concerns: moral discipline, scriptural seriousness, suspicion of sensual excess, hostility to idolatry
- Milton doesn't reject love or marriage but he distinguishes fallen love from ordered love

Antinomianism

- The belief that Christians are freed from moral law by grace. Milton rejects this.
- Eve's reasoning can sound dangerously antinomian when she implies that transgression or testing might prove virtue, Eve's defying of conventional hierarchy and believing she is immune from punishment
- Book 9 warns that liberty without obedience becomes self-deception

The pope and Roman Catholicism in Milton's Day

- Milton saw the pope as a symbol of spiritual tyranny and false authority
- Anti-Catholicism was common in Protestant England
- Satan's manipulation of hierarchy and false authority may echo Milton's fear of corrupt religious power. Satan behaves like a false priest or tyrant, offering counterfeit enlightenment

Felix Culpa

- Christian theology says that the fall is catastrophic but also makes redemption through Christ possible
- Book 9 is tragic, but not finally despairing. The Fall creates loss but Christian history later turns that loss into the possibility of grace

Machiavelli

- Associated with political cunning, manipulation, performance and the use of deception for power
- Satan's 'mediated fraud and malice' makes him Machiavellian
- Satan's power is strategic rather than physical. He succeeds through political manipulation, rhetoric etc

Jacobean anti-Hero

- Jacobean drama often features clarification villains who soliloquise, plot and attract audience fascination despite their evil
- Milton makes Satan dramatically compelling, but this are a

The tragic unities

- Classical tragedy often values unity of action, place and time.
- Book 9, through epic, becomes concentrated
- Milton's epic temporarily becomes drama: the fall feels immediate, staged, and emotionally intense

Adam unparadiz'd

- Milton originally considered writing the fall as a Drama
- Book 9 retains dramatic features: Soliloquy, dialogue, staged temptation, marital conflict, tragic confrontation

Theodicy

- Means defending God's justice despite the existence of evil. Milton's stated aim is to "justify the ways of God to men"
- Book 9 locates the fall in human choice rather than divine design

Scala naturae

- Great Chain of Being – ranks creation from God down through angels, humans, animals, plants and matter

- Sin disrupts hierarchy. Satan descends into a beast; Eve challenges Adam; appetite usurps reason. The fall is a collapse of cosmic order

Ordo Amoris

- Augustine's ordo amoris means the "right ordering of love". Sin occurs when good things are loved in the wrong order
- Adam's love for Eve is good, but becomes sinful when he values her above god
- Adam's flaw is not love itself, but disordered love. "Death to mee as life"

Augustinian sin

- Saw sin as the will turning away from God toward the self or created things
- Eve's ambition and Adam's uxuriousness are both Augustinian sins: They turn from creator to creature, from divine order to self-will

Republican rhetoric

- Milton was a republican polemicist who defended the execution of Charles I and opposed monarchy

SECTION	KEY QUOTES
1-47: The Action and the Invocation	- "I now must change Those notes to Tragic; foul distrust, and breach disloyal" - "Sad task, yet argument not less but more Heroic than the wrath of stern Achilles" - "Celestial Patroness" - "Pleas'd me long choosing, and beginning late" - "Bases and tinsel trappings" "imblazon'd shields" - "Mee of these nor skilled nor studious" - "Not hers who brings it nightly to my ear"
48-49: Satan enters Eden	- "now improv'd in meditated fraud and malice, bent on mans destruction" - "There was a place, now not, though sin, not Time, first wraught the change" - "The serpent suttlest beast of all the field" - "His dark suggestions hide from sharpest sight"

	- “From inward grieve is bursting passion into complaints thus pour’d”
99-178: Satan apostrophises Eden and the Earth	- “And the more I see pleasures about me, so much more I feel torment within me, as from the hateful siege of contraries” - “Thus wrapt in mist of midnight Vapor glide obscure, and pride in every Bush and Brake” - “O foul descent! That I who erst contended with Gods to sit the highest am now constrained into a Beast, and mixt with bestial slime” - “Revenge, at first tough sweet, Bitter ere long back on it self recoiles; Let it; I reck not”
179-204: Satan enters the serpent	- “Where soonest he might finde The Serpent: him fast sleeping soon he found in Labyrinth of many a round self-rowld” - “In at his Mouth the Devil entered” - “The human pair” - “Then commune” - “And Eve first to her Husband thus began”
205-225: Eve addresses Adam on dividing their labours	- “Let us divide our labours” - “Our dayes work brought to little ... and th’hour of supper comes unearn’d”
226-269: Adam replies and reminds Eve of Satan’s forewarned seduction	- “for nothing lovelier can be found in Woman, than to studie houshold good” - “Yet not so strictly hath our Lord impos’d Labour” - “As wide as we need walk” - “Malicious foe” - “Where each to other speedie aide might lend at need” - “Conjugal love” - “Leave not the faithful side that gave thee being: - “The wife, where danger or dishonour lurks, safest and seemliest by her Husband staies, who guards her, or with her the worst endures”
270-289: Eve replies, hurt	- “With sweet austere composure thus reply’d” - “Adam, misthought of her to thee so dear?”
290-317: Adam with healing words replies	
318-341: Eve declares Eden were no Eden	- “his foul esteeme sticks no dishonour on our front, but turns foul on himself” - “What is faith, Love, Vertue unassaid Alone, without exterior help sustaind?”

thus exposed	- “And Eden were no Eden thus expos’d”
342-375: Adam warns eve	- “Wouldst thou approve thy constancie, approve first thy obedience” - “Go; for thy stay, not free, absents thee more”
376-396: Eve takes her leave and is compared to nymphs and goddesses	- “From her Husbands hand her hand soft she withdrew” - “Likest she seemd, Pomona when she fled Vertumnus, or to ceres in her prime, yet virgin of Proserpina from Jove”
397-423: Narrative interjection and Satan spies Eve	- “O much deceived, much failing, hapless Eve” - “Eve separate he spies”
424-472: Satan is made stupidly good by Eve’s beauty	- “As one who long in populous city pent, where Houses thick and sewers annoy the Aire” - “Among the pleasant villages and Farmes” - “With Nymphlike step fair Virgin pass” - “Her graceful innocence ... overawed his malice” - “For the time remained stupidly good”
473-510: Satan’s soliloquy and description of him as a snake	- “The enemy of Mankind”
511-531: Epic similes and pretending to be dumb	- “A when a ship by skilful steersman wrought” - “From every beast, more duteous at her call, then at Circean call” - “His fraudulent temptation thus began”
532-566: Satan and Eve’s first conversation	- “Thy awful brow” “Celestial Beautie” - “Into the heart of Eve is words made way”
567-613: Empress speech	- “Empress of this fair world, resplendent Eve” - “Strange alteration in me, to degree of Reason in my inward powers” - “Sovran of Creatures, universal Dame”
614-646: Discussion of the fruit and leading the way	- “So talked the spirited sly snake” - “Lead then, said Eve” - “Hee leading swiftly rowld in tangles, made intricate seem strait”

	- “Misleads th’ amazed night-wanderer from his way”
647-678: Satan’s performance	- “To man, and indignation at his wrong, new parts put on” - “As when of some old Orator renowned in Athens or free Rome, where eloquence flourished” - “Each act won audience ere the tongue”
679-732: O sacred wise and wisdom-giving plant	- “Queen of this universe, doe not believe those rigid threats of Death; ye shall not die: how should ye? By the fruit? It gives you life to knowledge” - “Knowledge of Good and Evil; of Good, how just? Of evil, if what is evil be real, why not known, since easier shunnd?” - “Your eyes that seem so cleere, yet are but dim, shall perfetly be then opened and cleared, and ye shall be as gods”
733-779: His words into her heart ‘too easie entrance won’	- “Into her heart too easie entrance won” - “His perswasive words, impregn’d with reason, to her seeming, and with truth”
780-794: ‘She plucked, she ate’	- “So saying, her rash hand in evil hour forth reaching to the fruit, she pluck’d, she eat” - “Earth felt the wound, and Nature from her seat sighing through all her works gave signs of woe” - “Greedily she ingorg’d without restraint” - “Not without song: each morning, and due praise shall tend thee, and the fertil burden of thy branches offer’d free to all”
795-833: ‘O sovereign, virtuous, precious of all trees’	- “Our great Forbidder” - “But to Adam in what sort shall I appeer?” - “Keep the odds of knowledge in my power without copartner? So to add what wants in femal sex” - “Render me more equal, and perhaps a thing not undesirable, sometime superior: for inferior who is free?” - “And Adam wedded to another Eve ... a Death to think” - “Adam shall share with me in bliss or woe: so dear I love him, that with him all deaths I could endure, without him live no life”
834-855: Adam makes his garland	- “Adam the while waiting desirous her return, had wove of choicest flours a Garland” - “In her face excuse came prologue and apologise to prompt”
856-885: Eve’s proposal	- “Opener my eyes Dimm erst, dilated spirits, ampler heart, and growing up to Godhead” - “Thou therefore also taste, that equal lot may joyne us, equal joy, as equal love; least thou not tasting, different degree Disjoyne us”

886-916: Adam, bone of my bone	- “While horror chill ran through his veins, and all his joints relaxed” - “From his slack hand the Garland wreath’d for Eve/ Down drop’d, and all the faded roses shed” - “Flesh of flesh, bone of my bone”
917-959: Adam considers	- “Adventurous Eve” - “Nor can I think that God, creator wise, though threatening, will in earnest so destroy his prime creatures” - “However I with thee have fixt my lot, certain to undergone like doom, if death consort with thee, Death is to mee as life” - “The bond of nature draw me to my owne, my own in thee, for what thou art is mine; our state cannot be severed, we are one, one flesh; to loose thee were to loose my self”
960-989: eve, glorious trial of exceeding love	- “o glorious trial of exceeding love, illustrious evidence, example high!” - “Not Death, but life augmented, Op’nd eyes, new hopes, new joyes” - “Taste so divine, that what of sweet before Hath toucht my sense, flat seems to this”
990-1016: Adam eats	- “As of choice to incur Divine displeasure for her sake, or Death.” - “She gave him of that fair enticing fruit with liberal hand” - “Not deceived, but fondly overcome with Femal charm” - “Nature gave a second groan” - “Wept at completing of the mortal sin” - “As with new wine intoxicated both they swim in mirth, and fansie themselves that they feel divinity within them” - “Carnal desire enflaming”
1017-1033: Adam’s amorous address to Eve	- “nor known till now true relish, tasting” - “For never did thy beautie since the day I saw thee first and wedded thee, adorned with all perfections, so enflaming my sense”
1034-1066: Post-lapsarian sex	- “Her hand he seis’d” - “There they thir fill of love and loves disport took largely, of their mutual guilt the Seale, The solace of their sin” - “Naked left to guilty shame” - “Herculean Samson from the Harlot-lap of Philistean Delilah”
1067-1098: They clothe themselves in leaves	- “True in our fall, false in our promised rising” - “Since our eyes Op’nd we find indeed, and find we know both Good and Evil, Good lost, and Evil got”

	- “If this be to know, which leaves us naked thus, of honour void” - “O might I here in solitude live savage” - “Hide me, where I may never see them more”
1134-1161: Adam and Eve’s first argument	- Nor only Teares rained at their eyes, but high winds worse within began to rise, high passions, anger, hate, mistrust, suspicion, discord” - “Shook sore their inward state of mind, clam region once and full of peace, now tost and turbulent” - “To sensual appetite, who from beneath usurping over Sovran reason claimed superior sway” - “Let none henceforth seek needless cause to approve the faith they owe; when earnestly they seek such proof, conclude, they then begin to faile” - “Was I to have never parted from thy side? As good have grown there still a lifeless rib.” - “Being as I am, why didst not thou the Head command me absolutely not to go” - “Hadst thou been firm and fixt in thy dissent, neither had I transgress’d, nor thou with mee”
1162-1189: Second argument and end of the book	- “Yet willingly chose rather Death with thee” - “Not enough severe it seems, in thy restraint” - “What could I more? I warned thee, admonished thee, foretold the danger, and the lurking enemie that lay in wait; beyond this had been force, and force upon free will hath no place” - “And perhaps I also erred in overmuch admiring what seemed in thee so perfect” - “Him who to worth in Women overtrusting” - “And left to her self, if evil thence ensue, she first his weak indulgence will accuse” - “Thus in mutual accusation spent the fruitless hours”

MARRIAGE

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Their marriage is utterly unique due to its theological origin as the only marriage	“Then commune”	Suggests mutual discourse where each has the same authority as the other, something that would’ve been unusual to a contemporary audience where patriarchal beliefs dominated dynamics between men and women, preventing women from having equal freedom of expression and opinion
	“Each to other speedie aide might lend at	Suggests a relationship of mutual dependence and support, where

untainted by sin, a perfection unreachable for later post-lapsarian readers	need”	neither is subordinate and more reliant on the other Matthew Jordan: “Eve is in significant respect an equal, a companion for Adam” – reinforces the pre-lapsarian idea of balanced intellect and respect
	“Eve first to her husband thus began”	Shows an unexpected subversion of gender roles, where not only does Eve initiate their elate, but Adam isn’t named and is referenced only in relation to Eve. Demonstrates that in a pre-lapsarian Eden, female autonomy and power are part of divine order, not rebellion Adam gains importance only by his relationship to eve – subverts contemporary patriarchal notion that women are defined by their male counterparts, be that their sons, fathers or husbands/
	“Conjugal love”	Presents their relationship as sacred and pure and a model of rational, virtuous affection Aligns with later feminist views that were largely unheard of during the time of Milton writing, such as Diane McColley who suggested that Milton’s “He for God only, she for God in him” from book 4 does not imply hierarchy, but rather interdependence and a unity of origin.
Shown to be logical, considering the different interpretations of God’s intentions	“Supper comes unearn’d”	Eve references ‘The parable of the Talents’ when she argues that they should do as much work in the garden as possible and therefore split up
	“Yet not so strictly hath our Lord impos’d Labour”	Argues in line with ‘The Parable of the Vineyard’ which says that they need not work so hard, as long as they have faith in God
Milton humanises Adam and Eve through psychological	“For while so near each other ... looks intervene and ... casual discourse draw on”	Eve’s rational arguments reveal an awareness of temptation and desire as well as articulate reasoning
	“Well hast thou motion’d, well thy thoughts imploy’d”	Adam’s courteous response at first affirms her intelligence and reveals mutual respect

realism, presenting marital tensions through realistic dialogue and linguistic nuance Grounds the biblical story in recognisable emotional experience		Yet his praise is tinged with condescension, anticipating the post-lapsarian notion that a woman's wisdom is limited
	"nothing lovelier can be found in woman, than to studie houshold good"	Suggests that a woman's intelligence is of minor importance to her domesticity, subtly reinstating domestic expectation and foreshadowing post-lapsarian gender dynamics Marcia Landy argues that Milton is committed to "the centrality of marriage, to the designated roles of the man as creator and woman as procreator, submissive to her husband's natural authority" Milton relates their marriage to contemporary views through Adam's patronising language Creating tension between ideal equality and contemporary realism, imbuing his depiction with reminders to the readers that we are fallen
	Makes their relationship relatable by imbuing it with tension. Fulfilling his aim of explaining the ways of God and the Fall to his society by allowing his readers to relate and therefore understand the story easier	
	"Let us divide our labours"	Eve's desire for independence mirrors contemporary anxieties about female autonomy Shannon Miller notes that "Milton would've seen the active involvement of powerful women in the English Civil War ... these women defied cultural expectations." Independence reflects the political reality of changing gender roles in Milton's England, enhancing the applicability of this story to contemporary feelings and dynamics Makes the familiar story feel strange by presenting it in a relatable way, balancing both unity and tensions here previously only supreme perfection was described. This reflects his aim in Book 1 to do something "unattempted yet In prose or rhyme" By giving Eve self-consciousness and logic, he departs from Genesis' simple account.
	"Virgin Majestie of Eve, as one who loves, and some unkindness meets, with sweet	The narrator's tone oscillates between admiration and unease, presenting Eve as both a rational and composed person who can hide

	austere composure”	her irritation for her benefit but also simultaneously as cunning and deceptive, reflecting the male gaze’s potential ambivalence toward female power
	“One night or two with wanton growth derides”	Milton’s language oscillates between relying on Adam and Eve’s pre-lapsarian condition and assuming post-lapsarian interpretations and ideas Shows how their task of gardening Eden is never ending and therefore they cannot be idle with their duties ‘Wanton’ can mean lush or female sexual incontinence- transforming this phrase into an allegory for women being wild and untameable. By using words that carry both pre and postlapsarian resonances, Milton weaponises the reader’s fallen consciousness
Portrayal consciously echoes and critiques the marriage debates of the time, situating Paradise Lost within a current and highly relevant time of political and theological discourse	“Short retirement urges sweet returne” – Adam’s kindness and generosity towards his wife where he seems to accept Eve’s wishes - uxoriousness	Swetnam-Sownam pamphlet debate epitomised early modern misogyny and proto-feminist defiance “If you forbear her, It makes her bold, and if you chasten her, then she will turn to serpent” – direct reference to Genesis reveals how misogynistic views were justified by the biblical story and many contemporaries based their views on the interpretation of the bible Milton – impact on people’s beliefs by adjusting their reading of the original genesis story
	Milton’s divorce tracts argue for “the liberty of the individual” and see forced marital obedience and household unhappiness as ‘tyranny’, suggesting a belief in female autonomy that can be recognised in Eve’s ambition and independent nature Defensio Secunda – suggests that women are ‘inferior’, ambivalent views even within Milton himself	

LOVE

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Love is a contributing factor to the fall Love becomes form of moral weakness	“The bond of nature draw me to my owne ... to loose the were to loose myself”	Adam defines his identity through eve Here love becomes self-consuming and Eve replaces God as Adam’s primary allegiance Adam’s love Is therefore idolatrous, violating divine hierarchy Stanley Fish “For by choosing her her implicates her in his idolatry, absorbing her into a love that is self-love”
	“Adam the while waiting desirous her return, had wove of choicest flours a Garland”	While Milton valued mutual affection in marriage, he believed in a hierarchical structure where the husband is superior – Divorce Tracts John Peter: “Adam’s devotion to his wife can fairly be called magnificent, and we should be less than human if we did not admire and honour him for it”
	“Not deceived but fondly overcome with Femal charm”	Adam chooses sin, chooses his love for Eve over devotion to God ‘Fondly’ implies irrational, excessive love C.S Lewis – “Adam fell by uxuriousness” Vs John Peter notes that there is ambiguity in ‘fondly’ that can be read positively “Adam falls ‘fondly’ – foolishly, lovingly. And we fall with him, sharing his generous improvidence, trusting his love” Common theme at the time: Stephen Greenblatt who characterises Othello as being too in love with his wife Saint Jerome latin writings “An adulterer is he who is too ardent a lover of his wife” Becomes a commonplace of anti-erotic Christian polemic in the early modern era
	“Certain to undergone like doom, if death consort with thee, Death is to mee as life”	Total collapse of moral judgment Love overrides fear of divine punishment Love her becomes fatalistic, self-destructive and a rejection of divine authority Mirrors tragic heroism – but Milton may critique it as false heroism Milton critiques the “knightly romances” of his time by portraying Adam’s love as a weakness rather than a virtue that brings victory
	“Flesh of flesh, bone of my bone”	Directly from Genesis Biblical echo elevates their union as sacred But in this context it becomes justification for sin Adam uses unity to rationalise disobedience Love becomes a rhetorical tool that’s used to justify moral failure

		Critic Michael Bryson argues that Adam and Eve serve as the ultimate example of fin'amor, choosing each other over God and Law of the universe John Leanord "Adam makes the right moral choice when he chooses to die for love"
Milton distinguishes between different kinds of love Pre-lapsarian vs postlapsarian	"Conjugal love"	'Conjugal' implies lawful, structured love, aligned with divine order Prelapsarian love is part of a harmonious hierarchy
	"Where to each other speedie aide might lend at need"	Love is presented as cooperative, functional, mutual Active and balanced, based on shared purpose rather than dependency
	"Carnal desire enflaming" "As with new wine intoxicated both they swim in mirth" "Nor known til now true relish, tasting"	Shift from conjugal to carnal – order to excess Intoxicated suggests loss of reason, overwhelming sensation Bodily, uncontrolled, irrational Driven by appetite rather than harmony Postlapsarian love is hedonistic, centred on physical appetite Spiritual appreciation is replaced with sexual gratification Voltaire (1738): "in all other poems love is represented as a vice; in Milton only it is a virtue"

POWER

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Power is primarily rhetorical – Eve is persuaded rather than overpowered	"As of some old Orator renowned in Athens or free Rome"	Milton compares Satan to a classical republican orator For a poet who defended regicide and republicanism, this is charged territory The implication is that Satan's temptation is political rhetoric Aligns with Milton's awareness that rhetoric can be abused – especially after the collapse of the commonwealth Seduction here mirrors the persuasive power that once stirred revolution
	"Mediated fraud or malice"	Satan's strategic rather than physical power makes him resemble a Machiavellian Machiavelli associated with political cunning, manipulation, performance and the use of deception for power

	“Empress of this fair world” “Queen of this universe ... Sovran of Creatures”	The monarchical semantic field is deliberate excess – it flatters while quietly replacing Eden’s theocentric order with a courtly, competitive one Eve is invited to imagine herself as sovereign rather than steward – ambition is stirred first,, appetite second Milton’s Republican hostility to absolutism makes flattery a morally suspect mode of speech: Satan’s praise resembles tyrannical political sycophantic rhetoric
	“Strange alteration in me	Satan sells sin as enlightenment by co-opting Miltonic ‘reason’ (the highest human faculty) Alteration + degree mimics the language of morals/progressive development ‘Inward powers’ gives the impression of authentic self-improvement (a persuasive ethos appeal) Philip Gallagher “By believing this speech, Eve has already fallen”
Persuasion interacts with pre-existing desires Satan appeals to Eve’s latent ambition Power is co-produced between tempter and tempted	“Lead then, said Eve” “Freely taste” repeated twice in the book, once when Satan convinces Eve and again when Eve seduces Adam	Eve actively consents and participates Satan’s power requires Eve’s cooperation Persuasion is not inherently powerful without consent Human choice is the decisive factor Because Adam and Eve possessed free will their fall was not purely tragedy but felix culpa, allowing humans to learn and repent Aligns with Milton’s aim to “justify the ways of God to men”
	“Ye shall be as Gods”	Gilbert and Gubar: “Eve falls for exactly the same reason that Satan does: because she wants to be “as Gods” and because, like him, she is secretly dissatisfied with her place, secretly preoccupied with questions of ‘equality” “Let us divide our labours”
	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	“Easie” implies minimal resistance, suggesting something in Eve is already receptive Power requires receptivity
Pursuit of power is fundamentally self-defeating Both Eve and Satan seek	“The more I see pleasures about me, so much more I feel torment within me, as from the hateful siege of contraries”	From the beginning of the book, Milton presents a character who has pursued power and instead of gaining dominance has received psychological torment Psychomachia Circularity, ironically echoing the curling form of a snake NEMESIS – key part of Renaissance tragedy where punishment or downfall follows

elevation (through rebellion or knowledge) only to experience torment and pain	“Revenge ... bitter ere long back on itself recoiles”	‘hubris’, arrogance etc Milton presents ambition and pride as self-punishing. The pursuit of power creates its own collapse
	“Render me more equal, and perhaps, a thing not undesirable, sometime superior”	Her desire for equality leads to a collapse into shame and conflict The pursuit of power destroys the very condition she wants to improve, unity, equality, harmony Eve falls because “like [Satan], she is secretly dissatisfied with her place, secretly preoccupied with questions of ‘equality’” – Gilbert and Gubar
	“Your eyes that seem so cleere, yet are but dim, shall perfetly then be opened and cleared, and ye shall be as gods” “Since our eyes Op’nd we find indeed, and find we know both Good and Evil, Good lost, and Evil Got”	Satan frames knowledge as empowerment But knowledge only deprives rather than elevates Satans misuse of power mimics tyrannical leadership, his rhetoric reflecting populist tyranny
Power does have real, albeit limited, effects	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	He has active success Satan’s rhetoric is effective and transformative He gains real psychological influence and achieves rhetorical domination Language of victory and conquest
Satan successfully manipulates	“Impregn’d with reason, to her seeming, with truth”	Eve perceives falsehood as truth Satan has power over how Eve’s reality is understood
Eve influences Adam Self-destructive but still powerful	“Not deceieved, but fondly overcome”	Adam intially recognises the danger but Eve’s influence and power is strong enough to override his rational awareness Power affects even those who understand the consequences
Milton upholds	“Earth trembled from her	Power ultimately belongs to a larger system

the existence of true, absolute power in the form of divine authority	entrails” “Nature gave a second groan”	Cosmic reaction asserts higher authority Natural disorder reflects divine justice
	“As God in Heav’n is Center” “God hath pronounc’t it death to taste that Tree”	Milton compares god’s pervasive authority to a divine centre
	“His creating hand nothing imperfect or deficient left of all that he created	“If one is left at the end in any doubt as to God’s justice and love, the poem has failed” – Alistair fowler

GENDER

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Milton encodes Eve’s fall within a framework of gender hierarchy Eve is a morally corrupt and easily tempted	“Her rash hand in evil hour”	‘Rash’ suggests impulsivity, traditionally feminised lack of restraint Her fall is framed as a lack of reason that is replaced by emotion or desire Aligns with early modern stereotypes about feminine irrationality “The fall occurs when reason, stronger in the person of Adam, relinquishes its sovereignty over judgement ... to passion, which is stronger in the person of Eve. Eve’s weaker reason falls victim ...” – Fredson Bowers
	“From every beast, more duteous at her call then at Circean call”	Simile aligns eve with Circe, the enchantress who transforms men into beasts ‘Duteous’ suggests submission and control, implying Eve holds a hypnotic sexual power Diane McColley: “Eve is superior to Circe”
	“The wife, where danger or dishonour lurks, safest and seemliest by her husband staies, who guards her, or with her	Adam explicitly articulates a gender hierarchy where female safety is dependent on male authority Eve’s fall therefore becomes a consequence of stepping outside of this structure Reflects early modern patriarchal ideology Milton’s own divorce tracts advocate for male authority within marriage

	the worst endures” “From her husbands hand her hand soft she withdrew”	Defensio Secunda – suggests that women are ‘inferior’ Marcia Landy argues that Milton is committed to “the centrality of marriage, to the designated roles of the man as creator and woman as procreator, submissive to her husband’s natural authority”
	“Herculean Samson from the harlot-lap of Philistean Delilah”	Biblical allusion Samson – divinely empowered male hero Delilah – seductive woman that causes his downfall By aligning Eve with Delilah, Milton places her within a tradition of dangerous femininity, where female sexuality is a corrupting force Eve becomes part of a typology of destructive women ‘Harlot-lap’ – overt sexualisation, feminine sexuality is morally corrupt, degradation Milton subtly shifts responsibility towards Eve as the agent of male ruin “[Milton] serenely proposes to justify the ways of God to men, calls upon subservient female muses for the assistance that is his due (and in real life upon slavish daughters for the same sort of assistance), and at the same time wars upon women with a barrage of angry words” – Gilbert and Gubar
Eve presented as innocent woman easily corrupted Exempts her from simple blame	“Likest she seemd, Pomona when she fled Vertumnus ... Virgin of Proserpina from Jove”	Classical allusions to women who are victims of male pursuit Figures of innocence under threat Pursued rather than pursuing Vulnerable rather than predatory Goes against 17 th century traditional view that encouraged people to view women as the root of all evil and responsible for the fall of man
	“With nymphlike step fair virgin pass”	Connects Eve to pastoral purity Emphasises prelapsarian innocence Situates Eve within Renaissance ideals of feminine purity and harmony with nature
	“O much deceived, much failing, hapless Eve”	Foregrounds external manipulation ‘Hapless’ suggests lack of agency and misfortune Positions her as a tragic victim rather than moral aggressor
	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	Innocent trust rather than moral corruption Eve’s failure is credulity

Grants Eve psychological depth and rhetorical agency Her decision is reasoned rather than impulsive Her fall stems from universal human faculties rather than gendered flaws	“Our dayes work brought to little ... and th’hour of supper comes unearn’d”	Invokes ‘The parable of the talents’ “If [Eve’s] failure is to have meaning, we must grant with our whole hearts that she possessed the capacity for success” – Stella Revard
	“What is faith, love, vertue unnassaid alone, without exterior help sustaind”	Poses ration, echoes miltonic arguments in Areopagitica that virtue must be tested, not preserved through ignorance Eve’s reasoning aligns with Milton’s own Protestant emphasis on active moral engagement “The fall occurs when reason, stronger in the person of Adam, relinquishes its sovereignty over judgement ... to passion, which is stronger in the person of Eve. Eve’s weaker reason falls victim ...” – Fredson Bowers
Male flaws represented too Milton ultimately resists reducing the fall to gendered weakness Disobedience is fundamentally human rather than specifically	“Not deceived, but fondly overcome with Femal charm”	Knowingly chooses sin, not deceived Emotional weakness rather than intellectual error in the case of Adam “Milton, in contrast to Adam, illuminates strengths in Eve” – Mike Edward (“Domestick Adam” vs “Adventurous Eve”)
	“And the while waiting desirous her return, had wove of choicest flours a garland”	CS Lewis argues “Adam fell by uxuriousness” reframing the fall as a failure of male emotional excess

female		
Gender equality also represented	“The human pair” “And Eve first to her Husband thus began” “Where to each other speedie end might lend at need” “And perhaps I also erred in overmuch admiring what seemed in thee so perfect”	Diane McColley who suggested that Milton’s “He for God only, she for God in him” from book 4 does not imply hierarchy, but rather interdependence and a unity of origin.

SETTING

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Eden is not merely a backdrop but an active participant in the fall	“Satan involv’d in rising mist” “This wrapt in mist of midnight Vapor glide inducer, and prie in every Bush and Brake” “Such ambush hid among sweet flours and shades”	‘Mist’ ‘Vapour’ ‘obscure’ – create visual instability and concealment Eden enables deception ‘Ambush’ – militaristic language, Eden becomes a site of entrapment Actively facilitating Satan’s movement and deception Not neutral but facilitates Satan’s movements and deception
	“The season, prime for sweetest Sents and Aires” “Veiled in a cloud of Fragrance” “Carnation, purple, azure, or spect with Gold”	Overwhelming sensory imagery ‘Cloud of fragrance’ – almost suffocating immersive sensory environment This excess blurs boundaries between innocent enjoyment and temptation
	“Fixt on the fruit she gazed, which to behold might tempt alone” “An eager appetite, raised by the smell so savouries of that fruit”	‘Tempt alone’ – the fruit itself is sufficient ‘Raised by the smell’ – desire originates from external influence Eden actively generates desire within Eve Temptation is not purely satanic but environmentally reinforced

	“Luxurious by restraint” “Wanton growth ... tending to Wilde”	‘Wanton’ connotes sexual incontinence Even before the fall, Eden tends towards excess and disorder The environment itself creates latent instability
	“A goodly Tree far distant to behold Loaden with fruit of fairest colours mixt, Ruddie and Gold”	“[paradise lost’s] high action and amazing natural world can also be viewed ... as gloriously heroic” – Alistair fowler Even the natural world is rendered with epic grandeur The fruit becomes visually heroic, almost treasure-like, making temptation part of the poem’s ‘high action’
Eden is reflective – symbolically externalising internal states	“There was a place, now not, though sin, not Time, first wrought the change”	‘Sin ... wrought the change’ – explicitly links transformation to human action Eden does not change independently but rather responds to human sin Eden is reactive, not active
	“Satan involv’d in rising mist” “Thus wrapt in mist of midnight Vapor glide obscure”	Rather than Eden enabling Satan, the environment mirrors his moral obscurity and inner darkness The mist is a projection of Satan’s fallen state Eden reflects the presence of Evil rather than generating it
Environment amplifies existing vulnerabilities (Curiosity, ambition) Moral testing ground rather than active agent	“Luxurious by restraint” “Wanton growth ... tending to Wilde”	Eden’s abundance tests self-control Its fertility demands discipline and therefore it functions as a test of moral restraint
	“His creating hand nothing imperfect or deficient left”	Eden is perfectly ordered Temptation therefore cannot arise from a flaw in creation Rather the test lies in human response to perfection
	“Hee leading swiftly ... made intricate seem strait” “Empress, the way is readie, and not long, beyond a row of Myrtles on a Flat Fast by a Fountain one small Thicket past of blowing Myrrh and Balme”	The environment appears navigable but is misleading Eden amplifies susceptibility to guidance It tests judgement and independence

TRAGEDY

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Tragedy	“I now must change those notes to tragic; foul distrust and breach disloyal”	Metapoetic line signals a generic shift from epic to tragedy Foreground moral rupture and relational breakdown, key features of tragedy The abstract nouns elevate the Fall into a universal moral catastrophe, aligning it with classical tragic structure where internal flaws lead to irreversible consequences
	“Not deceived but fondly overcome with Femal charm”	Adam’s fatal flaw and Hamartia is his uxuriousness – Eve’s “Rash hand” C.S Lewis – “Adam fell by uxuriousness
	“Good lost, and Evil got”	Anagnorisis, tragic realisation comes too late Renaissance tragedy
	“Reason ... against his better knowledge” “To sensual appetite ... usurping over Sovran knowledge”	Shift from earlier books that focused on external warfare and heroic feats to internal conflict
	“Force upon free will hath no place” “Though sin, not Time, first wrought the change”	Unlike Greek tragedy, there is no blind fate Human choice and sin Christian moral tragedy
	BUT not purely tragic because of FELIX CULPA and Christian redemption remains possible	
Epic	“Sad task, yet argument not less but more Heroic than the wrath of stern Achilles”	Milton explicitly invokes Achilles to position his poem within the epic tradition, but claims moral superiority Christian moral epic superior “[Narrator] interjections and caveats draw attention to the arbitrary nature (and so ineffectiveness) of human language when faced with the task of expressing divinity” – Liam Haydon The narrator’s self-conscious framing reveals the difficulty of representing divine history in human poetic form. Yet Milton still attempts heroic language, suggesting language is inadequate but not

		useless
	“As when a ship by skilful steersman wrought”	Epic simile compares Satan’s skilful seduction through rhetoric to a ship being steered Potentially alludes to Odyssey Ironises epic heroism, as Satan’s ‘skill’ is used for deception, subverting traditional epic values Milton wanted to write an English Christian Epic that likely focused on British history or Arthurian legends, that could rival Virgil or Homer Instead of celebrating England, he makes the Fall of humanity his epic subject: Book 9 turns inward moral choice into epic action. The real battlefield is human will
	“A goodly Tree far distant to behold Loaden with fruit of fairest colours mixt, Ruddie and Gold”	“[paradise lost’s] high action and amazing natural world can also be viewed ... as gloriously heroic” – Alistair fowler Even the natural world is rendered with epic grandeur The fruit becomes visually heroic, almost treasure-like, making temptation part of the poem’s ‘high action’
	“Revenge, at first though sweet, Bitter ere long back on itself recoiles”	Alistair Fowler: “Satan who soliloquises may be thought of as choosing to be a Jacobean villain-hero” Satan resembles a stage villain’s self-conscious plotting. He knows revenge is self-destructive but performs villainy anyway, making him theatrically compelling rather than morally heroic.
Pastoral	“Among the pleasant villages and Farmes” “With Nymphlike step fair Virgin pass”	Idyllic imagery evokes pastoral simplicity and harmony, contrasting with epic warfare Eden as a space of natural abundance and peace
	“With Nymphlike step fair Virgin pass”	Classical pastoral imagery idealises Eve as part of a harmonious natural order Prelapsarian innocence Aligns Eve with Golden Age pastoral tradition
Dramatised	‘Earth felt the wound’	These lines function like stage reactions, externalising the Fall as a

	‘Nature shuddered’ Dramatic conflict between Adam and Eve at the end	visible, dramatic event The cosmos becomes an audience and participant, highlighting the theatrical impact “[Milton had] the power of displaying the vast, illuminating the awful, darkening the gloomy, and aggravating the dreadful” – Edmund Burke Milton turns the action into sublime cosmic catastrophe.
	“Thus they in mutual accusation spent the fruitless hours”	Shift into dialogue and conflict creates a dramatic scene of domestic tragedy Rising tension and emotional exchange
	“Each act won audience ere the tongue”	Explicit theatrical language frames Satan as a performer, reinforcing the idea that temptation itself is a dramatic performance
	The tragic unities - Classical tragedy often values unity of action, place and time. - Book 9, through epic, becomes concentrated - Milton’s epic temporarily becomes drama: the fall feels immediate, staged, and emotionally intense Adam unparadiz’d - Milton originally considered writing the fall as a Drama - Book 9 retains dramatic features: Soliloquy, dialogue, staged temptation, marital conflict, tragic confrontation	
Humanised	“And the serpent said unto the woman, Ye shall not surely die” (Genesis) vs “Do not believe those rigid threats of Death; ye shall not Die: how should ye? By the fruit? It gives you life to knowledge	Demotic language of genesis transformed into deceptive and psychologically intricate argument
	“For good unknown sure is not had, or had/ and yet unknown is as not had at all” vs “she took of the fruit thereof, and did eat	Milton gives us philosophical syllogism, epistemological reasoning, moral abstraction This psychological expansion makes the act understandable, makes Eve sympathetic, makes us inhabit her thought process We do not merely observe the fall We experience it internally

FREE WILL

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Milton suggests exercising your free will is worth losing paradise Freedom is necessary and valuable, even though it creates the possibility of sin	“Let us divide our labours”	Eve asserts autonomy and independence, initiating the conditions for moral testing Imperative signals active agency rather than passivity Her choice reflects Milton’s belief that virtue must be freely exercised rather than imposed Shannon Miller notes that “Milton would’ve seen the active involvement of powerful women in the English Civil War ... these women defied cultural expectations.”
	“Lead then, said Eve”	Eve’s consent matters because it proves that she could have chosen otherwise The line is brief but decisive, proving agency and free will rather than inevitability “If [Eve’s] failure is to have meaning, we must grant with our whole hearts that she possessed the capacity for success” – Stella Revard
	“Our dayes work brought to little ... th’hour of super comes unearn’d”	Eve’s reasoning is practical and rational, grounded in productivity Evidence of free will operating through reasoned judgement, not impulse, reinforcing Milton’s view that human beings must actively govern themselves
	“What is faith, love, vertue unassaid alone, without exterior help sustained?”	Eve argues that virtue must be tested in practice not preserved in isolation Tetrachordon: “men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law” Eve’s argument resembles Milton’s belief. However Eve’s ‘transgression’ doesn’t keep the law but destroys paradise, so Milton tests the limits of his own liberty principle
	“Go; for thy stay, not free, absents thee	Adam prioritises freedom over safety, suggesting that enforced

	more”	obedience is not just “Not free” implies that lack of freedom itself is a kind of moral absence
Temptation embedded in creation and necessary for freedom ‘Justify the ways of God to men’ Temptation is therefore not a flaw in creation but a necessity for genuine moral freedom	“The serpent subtlest beast of the field”	The presence of the serpent within Eden shows that temptation is embedded within creation ‘Subtlest’ implies intellectual challenge, making temptation a necessary and foretold test of discernment
	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	Suggests that temptation works through internal susceptibility, not coercion Free will is preserved because Eve is not forced, she is persuaded
	“Impregn’d with reason, to her seeming, and with truth”	Satan’s argument appears rational, meaning Eve must actively judge between truth and falsehood. This reflects Milton’s belief that moral truth must be discerned, not passively received.
	“Force upon free will hath no place”	Explicit statement of Miltonic theology God’s justice lies in allowing freedom – he does not compel or impose obedience Free will must operate without coercion, even if that leads to the fall “If one is left at the end in any doubt as to God’s justice and love, the poem has failed” – Alistair fowler Adam defends divine justice. The fall is human responsibility, not divine cruelty
The true test of free will is the ability to resist temptation with one’s reason	“Fixt on the fruit she gazed, which to behold might tempt alone”	Eve’s prolonged gaze indicates a failure of self-regulation The fruit doesn’t compel her – it’s her inability to withdraw attention that reveals a failure in free will
	“An eager appetite ... raised by the smell”	Desire is intensified but not imposed ‘Raised’ suggests amplification Free will is only meaningful when it results in self-restraint. Eve falls not because she is tempted, but because she yields.
Paradise is constructed as perfect to	“Conjugal love” “Where each to other speedie aide might lend”	Represents ordered, harmonious relationship aligned with divine hierarchy Mutuality and balance reinforce prelapsarian perfection

emphasise the cost of free will gone wrong	“With Nymphlike step fair Virgin pass” “The season, prime for sweetest sents and Aires”	Pastoral purity and innocence emphasise what is lost Sensory perfection heightens the sense of paradise as ideal
	“Carnal desire enflaming” “Thus in mutual accusation spent the fruitless hours”	Presents the tragic consequences of Eve’s transgression convincingly, deterring readers
The outcome validates God’s warning, proving divine authority is just and true	“Though sin, not Time, first wrought the change” “Good lost, and Evil got”	Emphasises that the Fall is caused by human choice, not divine design “Justify the ways of God to men” William Empson: “however wicked Satan’s plan may be, it is God’s plan too”

HIERARCHY/ ORDER

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Milton presents the fatal consequences of disobeying one’s superior Eve disobeys Adam and God	“Leave not the faithful side that gave thee being”	‘Gave thee being’ emphasises Adam’s ontological priority, reinforcing a divinely ordained hierarchy ‘Faithful side’ suggests both loyalty and spatial unity, so Eve’s departure becomes symbolic of disorder and disobedience
	“Wouldst thou approve thy constancie, approve first thy obedience”	Adam redefines virtue as obedience within hierarchy, not independent testing. The repetition of ‘approve’ suggests that constancy must be validated through submission, reinforcing hierarchical order as morally necessary “The goodness, happiness, and dignity of every being consists in obeying its natural superior and ruling its natural inferiors” – C.S Lewis
	“The wife ... safest and seemliest by her Husband Staies”	Protection of ‘safest’ ‘Seemliest’ introduces a normative moral standard, presenting

		hierarchy as both practical and appropriate
	“Earth felt the wound”	Disobedience has tragic consequences, showing that hierarchy is not merely social but embedded in the structure of creation. Breaking it produces universal disorder.
Disorder begins with separation and culminates in internal chaos	“From her Husbands hand her hand soft she withdrew”	The physical separation symbolises rupture in hierarchy Repetition of ‘hand’ highlights the breaking of connection and guidance ‘Eve separate he spies’ Eve falls because “like [Satan], she is secretly dissatisfied with her place, secretly preoccupied with questions of ‘equality’” – Gilbert and Gubar
	“To sensual appetite ... usurping over Sovran reason”	Political metaphor: Suggests illegitimate seize of power The hierarchy within the self of reason over appetite collapses, mirroring external disobedience CONTEXT!!
	“High passions, anger, hate, mistrust, suspicious discord”	Accumulation of abstract nouns reflects emotional chaos. The ordered harmony of Eden is replaced by psychological disorder, showing hierarchy’s collapse at every level
Milton also presents Adam as uxorious and emphasises free will, meaning Eve’s rebellion of him is somewhat admirable Hierarchy fails because Adam misuses his authority	“Not deceived, but fondly overcome with Femal charm” “Death is to mee as life”	Adam’s fall is caused by emotional excess, not deception He places his wife above God, disrupting divine hierarchy ORDO AMORIS (Augustinian concept) Paradox reveals collapse of rational hierarchy, where moral distinctions lose meaning “Milton, in contrast to Adam, illuminates strengths in Eve” – Mike Edward (“Domestick Adam” vs “Adventurous Eve”)

Eve's resistance to hierarchy can be seen as rational and even admirable	"Let us divide our labours" "Th'hour of supper comes unearn'd"	Eve proposes independence through rational organisation, not rebellion The inclusive imperative suggests collaboration rather than defiance Shannon Miller notes that "Milton would've seen the active involvement of powerful women in the English Civil War ... these women defied cultural expectations."
	"What is faith, love, vertue unassaid alone?"	Eve challenges passive obedience, aligning with Miltonic arguments that virtue must be actively tested Tetrachordon: "men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law" Eve's argument resembles Milton's belief. However Eve's 'transgression' doesn't keep the law but destroys paradise, so Milton tests the limits of his own liberty principle
	For inferior who is free?"	Eve explicitly questions hierarchy, linking freedom with equality, suggesting that subordination may contradict true liberty

INNOCENCE

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Presentation of prelapsarian perfection vs postlapsarian lust	"Conjugal love"	Implies ordered, lawful and spiritual love, aligned with divine hierarchy Prelapsarian innocence is defined by restraint and harmony, not absence of desire
	"Carnal desire enflaming"	Stark contrast 'Carnal' reduces love to bodily appetite, while 'enflaming' suggests loss of control Innocence is replaced by excess and sexuality, marking moral degradation
	"As with new wine intoxicated ... they swim"	'Intoxicated' implies loss of rational control, suggesting

	in mirth”	postlapsarian experience is distorted and illusory, not true fulfilment
	‘Naked left to guilty shame’	Shifts innocent openness to self-conscious exposure. Innocence replaced by shame and division
Eve’s innocence could be seen as what caused the tragedy	“Likest she seemed, Pomona when she fled Vertumnus, yet virgin of Proserpina from Jove”	Allusions to Pomona and proserpina position Eve as a figure of threatened chastity, not temptation. “If [Eve’s] failure is to have meaning, we must grant with our whole hearts that she possessed the capacity for success” – Stella Revard
	“With Nymphlike step fair virgin pass”	Pastoral imagery idealises Eve as a part of natural harmony. ‘Virgin’ signals innocence, but also lack of knowledge, suggesting susceptibility “Milton’s portrayal of Eve stands in radiant contrast to the sly or naïve temptress who bore her name previous to the writing of Paradise Lost” – Diane McColley
	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	‘Too easie’ implies unguarded openness ‘Heart’ suggests sincerity rather than corruption Eve’s innocence becomes a point of entry for deception
Eve was never innocent to begin with	“Fixt on that fruit she gazed, which to behold might tempt alone”	Suggests active fascination, not passive observation. The fruit does not impose temptation – Eve lingers, implying pre-existing curiosity
	“An eager appetite... raised by the smell”	Suggests amplification rather than creation
	“Render me more equal ... perhaps superior” “What is faith, Love, vertue unassaid alone?”	Eve expresses ambition for equality and power, suggesting latent aspiration and pride Intellectual restlessness
	“From every beast more duteous at her call then at Circean call”	Figure associated with enchantment, transformation and dangerous female power Seductive, satanic quality Diane McColley: “superior to Croce”
Adam totally innocent	“Not deceived, but fondly overcome”	Adam is not intellectually flawed, but emotionally vulnerable His innocence does not protect him from uxuriousness

BLAME FOR THE FALL

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Eve's ambition and agency causes the fall	"Let us divide our labours" "Our dayes work brought to little ... and th'hour of supper comes unearned" "Eden were no Eden thus exposed"	Eve initiates separation, creating the conditions for temptation Inclusive imperative masks autonomy as cooperation Tetrachordon: "men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law" Eve's argument resembles Milton's belief. However Eve's 'transgression' doesn't keep the law but destroys paradise, so Milton tests the limits of his own liberty principle
	"Lead then, said Eve"	Eve's consent matters because it proves that she could have chosen otherwise The line is brief but decisive, proving agency and free will rather than inevitability "If [Eve's] failure is to have meaning, we must grant with our whole hearts that she possessed the capacity for success" – Stella Revard
	"Our dayes work brought to little ... th'hour of supper comes unearn'd"	Eve's reasoning is practical and rational, showing she isn't impulsive. This reinforces that the fall stems from misguided reason rather than ignorance "The fall occurs when reason, stronger in the person of Adam, relinquishes its sovereignty over judgement ... to passion, which is stronger in the person of Eve. Eve's weaker reason falls victim ..." – Fredson Bowers
	"Eden were not Eden thus expos'd"	Aphoristic structure gives the statement a tone of authoritative moral generalisation, resembling Satan's earlier rhetorical style Linguistic shift shows she has partially integralised Satanic reasoning
	"Render me more equal ... perhaps superior"	Explicit ambition for equality and elevation, aligning her with

		the sin of pride (traditionally satanic) Her fall originates from dissatisfaction and internal aspiration rather than external coercion Eve falls because “like [Satan], she is secretly dissatisfied with her place, secretly preoccupied with questions of ‘equality’” – Gilbert and Gubar
	“I warn’d thee, I admonish’d thee, foretold the Danger and the lurking Enemie ... beyond this had bin force, and force upon free will hath no place”	The tricolon emphasises Adam’s fulfilled duty Invokes Milton’s broader theology, Adam could not prevent Eve without violating divine principles Good must be actively chosen rather than unforced “If one is left at the end in any doubt as to God’s justice and love, the poem has failed” – Alistair Fowler Adam defends divine justice. The fall is human responsibility, not divine cruelty God does not coerce obedience
	“Being as I am, why didst not thou the Head command me absolutely not to go”	Eve paradoxically criticises Adam for not exercising stricter authority ‘Head’ invokes patriarchal hierarchy Exposes total contradiction: Eve simultaneously resists and demands authority Line reveals how blame becomes circular and unstable
Satan’s responsible	“Improv’d in mediated fraud and malice”	Deliberate planning and deception Satan’s actions are premeditated, making him morally culpable
	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	Satan’s rhetoric penetrates Eve’s inner being ‘Won’ implies active conquest, framing him as the agent of corruption
	“Impregn’d with reason, to her seeming, and with truth”	Satan manipulates logic itself, presenting falsehood as truth. His power lies in distorting reason, not overwhelming it
	“Queen of this universe” “Empress of this fair Sovran world”	Flattery targets Eve’s latent ambition, showing Satan’s awareness of her psychology He exploits rather than creates her desire

Adam as responsible	“Not deceived but fondly overcome with Femal charm” “Perhaps I also erred in overmuch admiring”	The adversative “Not...but” is crucial – Adam is not misled, but chooses knowingly ‘Fondly’ suggests emotional excess, uxuriousness “Milton, in contrast to Adam, illuminates strengths in Eve” – Mike Edward (“Domestick Adam” vs “Adventurous Eve”)
	“As of choice to incur divine displeasure”	Emphasises free will and conscious rebellion, making Adam arguably more culpable than Eve
	“Death is to mee as life”	Hyperbolic paradox reveals collapse of rational hierarchy, as Adam elevates Eve above God ORDO AMORIS (Augustinian disordered love)
	“Was I to have never parted from thy side? As good have grown there still a liveless Rib”	Challenges Adam’s authority, exposing the implications of absolute dependence Reduces enforced obedience to ontological stagnation – a denial of her humanity and agency Suggests that true life requires independence, aligning with Miltonic ideas about liberty Frames obedience as dehumanising

AMBITION

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Eve is ambitious before she ever meets the Devil	“Let us divide our labours” “Our dayes work brought to little ... and th’hour of supper comes unearned”	The imperative suggests initiative and autonomy that’s veiled as collaboration Eve seeks efficiency and improvement, indicating ambition as a form of rational self-advancement, not yet sinful Shannon Miller notes that “Milton would’ve seen the active involvement of powerful women in the English Civil War ... these women defied cultural expectations.”
	“Our dayes work brought to little ... th’hour of supper comes unearn’d”	Eve evaluates productivity in almost economic terms Invokes the ‘parable of the talents’

	“Eden were no Eden thus expos’d”	Aphoristic and authoritative, reflects intellectual ambition, Eve seeks a higher form of
	“Render me more equal ... perhaps superior”	Desire for justice that’s escalated into hierarchical disruption, aligning her with Satan’s own aspirational fall Eve falls because “like [Satan], she is secretly dissatisfied with her place, secretly preoccupied with questions of ‘equality’” – Gilbert and Gubar
Satan exploits Eve’s ambition	“Queen of this universe” “Empress”	Satan’s flattery mirrors Eve’s existing aspirations These titles amplify her latent desire for elevation, suggestion ambition activated, not implanted
	“Ye shall be as Gods” “Knowledge of Good and Evil”	Appeals directly to aspirational transcendence Intellectual advancement, self-improvement
Adam isn’t ambitious	“As wide as we need walk” “Yet not so strictly hath our lord impos’d Labour”	Limits desire to necessary with ‘need’ Contentment and restraint Adam embodies acceptance rather than aspiration
	“Yet not so strictly hath our Lord impos’d labour”	‘Parable of the vineyard’ Freedom from burden, satisfaction with divine provision
	“Wouldst that approve thy cosntancie, approve first thy obedience”	Equates virtue with stability and submission, rejecting Eve’s idea of testing and growth “The goodness, happiness, and dignity of every being consists in obeying its natural superior and ruling its natural inferiors” – C.S Lewis

HUMAN FLAWS/PERFECTION

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Adam and Eve are by definition	“His creating hand nothing imperfect or deficient left”	Absolute terms establish Edenic humanity as divinely perfect Reflects theological orthodoxy: creation is flawless, reinforcing

perfect and Milton presents them as different from postlapsarian humans AND himself, the postlapsarian narrator		that the Fall cannot originate in divine error “Her prelapsarian actions ... are not foreshadowings of necessary sin, but illustrations of actual and potential virtue ... a fall is always possible but never inevitable” – Diane McColley
	“With Nymphlike step fair virgin pass”	Idealised pastoral imagery elevates Eve beyond ordinary humanity into a mythic, perfected State, aligning her with classical purity “If [Eve’s] failure is to have meaning, we must grant with our whole hearts that she possessed the capacity for success” – Stella Revard
	“Conjugal love”	Suggests a perfectly ordered relationship, governed by harmony
	“Mee of these nor skilled nor studious”	Narrator explicitly distinguishes himself as a postlapsarian human from the perfection of Adam and Eve
Adam and Eve could never be perfect because they are human Perfect in creation but capable of error	“Into her heart too easie entrance won”	Suggests structural vulnerability Implies that even in innocence, the human mind is susceptible to deception
	“Fixt on the fruit she gazed”	Sustained gaze suggests active engagement with temptation, indicating that desire and curiosity exist prior to the fall
	“Force upon free will hath no place”	The necessity of free will implies that possibility of error, meaning perfection cannot be absolute – it must include the capacity to fall
Already flawed before the fall – ambition and uxuriousness	“Let us divide our labours” “Render me more equal ... perhaps superior”	Dissatisfaction Desire for elevation shows that hierarchical tension exists before the fall Adam and Eve are relatable because they possess recognisably human flaws
	“Not deceived but fondly overcome with Femal charm” “The bond of nature draw me to my owne”	Adam prioritises attachment over divine command “The fall occurs when reason, stronger in the person of Adam, relinquishes its sovereignty over judgement ... to passion, which is stronger in the person of Eve. Eve’s weaker reason falls victim ...” – Fredson Bowers

		“Milton, in contrast to Adam, illuminates strengths in Eve” – Mike Edward (“Domestick Adam” vs “Adventurous Eve”)
The fall exposes the illusion of perfection	“good lost, and Evil got”	Balanced phrasing suggests a clear moral reversal, revealing that the prior ‘good’ was unstable
	“To sensual appetite ... usurping over Sovran reason”	The fall reveals the latent instability of human nature, where reason can be overthrown and overridden by baser desires

SATAN

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Satan as the tragic protagonist that propels the epic’s action	“Bent on man’s destruction” “Bitter ere long back on it self recoile”	Satan consciously embraces revenge even as he recognises it will spite him
	“The more I see pleasures about me, so much more I feel torment within me	The tragic interiority of his first soliloquy places him at the emotional centre of the book This inward Psychomachia echoes the dramatic mode Milton originally conceived for the fall Recalls the conflicted self-scrutiny of renaissance tragic heroes
	“As when of some old orator renowned in Athens or free Rome”	Explicit comparison to classical republican eloquence Milton revered republican Rome- yet her eloquence becomes the instrument of corruption Kahn: “Milton is so disillusioned by rhetoric that PL represents the turning of humanist rhetoric against itself” Milton’s use of rhetoric in his political texts (Areopagitica, populo anglicano) Milton has lost faith with rhetoric and presents it as corruption
	“From inward griefe his bursting passions unto complaints thus pour’d”	Milton affords Satan narrative significance by giving him multiple lengthy speeches “Satan who soliloquises may be thought of as choosing to be a Jacobean villain-hero”
	“Knowledge of Good and Evil;	Satan echoes Miltonic arguments

	Of Good how just? Of evil, if what is evil Be real, why not known, if easier shunnd?"	Satan frames prohibition as epistemological absurdity Resembles Milton's arguments in Areopagitica "I cannot praise a fugitive and cloistered virtue" Makes Satan intellectually compelling and elevates him into tragic territory He initiates the arguments and ideas which lead Eve to fall Milton even gives us some of his great teachings through Satan But he does not complete the fall – he can question but he cannot compel – this limits his protagonist status
	"Eve separate he spies"	Satan studies eve's isolation Recognises her ambition and exploits her intellectual curiosity Uses flattery, classical rhetorical devices and logical sophistry Reflects renaissance humanist training in rhetoric – Milton shows how such tools can be perverted
	"As when a ship by skillful steersman wrought" "Flies through chaos" (echoes Odysseus in book 2) "Joy brightens his crest" (Satan is like a soldier leading Eve)	Epic similes echoing the odyssey/ the epic genre to highlight Satan's seductive qualities Suggests that Satan resembles Odysseus Epic similes depict him as an epic hero

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Satan is not the protagonist	His entry into "The serpent subtlest beast of all the field" signals not triumph but diminution "O foul descent!"	Marks a fall not only from Heaven but from epic stature Unlike the defiant warrior of books 1-3, this Satan operates parasitically, hiding "dark suggestions" within another creatures form Isn't that far of a departure from genesis account "Readers must finally decide for themselves whether Milton satanises the epic or measures Satan against an epic standard and finds him wanting" – John Leonard Satan has epic grandeur in memory, but his present degradation undercuts him.

		Milton measures him against epic height and finds him morally diminished
	“In at his mouth the devil entered”	Satan acts parasitically rather than heroically His agency is hidden and indirect
	“Wrapped in mist of midnight vapour glide obscure”	Imagery of concealment replaces epic spectacle Milton intentionally deflates Satan’s grandeur “This wavering, slumbering, deceptive state of consciousness is another factor that gives Satan fictional depth, concealing him from our full knowledge” - John Carey
	“Let it; I reckon not”	Complicates any reading of Satan as a tragic hero in the Aristotelian sense Unlike classical tragedy, where fate overwhelms the protagonist, Satan repeatedly recognises his own culpability

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Satan ultimately functions less as an autonomous tragic centre than as the necessary vehicle through which a providentially anticipated temptation is enacted The true epic crisis	“O much deceived, much failing, hapless Eve”	Narrator’s interjection directs our tragic attention towards Eve’s vulnerability rather than Satan’s malice Reminds us that Eve is the tragic subject and the epic crisis lies in her choice
	“What is faith, love, virtue untried alone without exterior help sustained”	Satan merely insinuates – Eve interprets, evaluates and chooses The real crisis is not Satan’s rhetoric but Eve’s reasoning The fall occurs when she internalises temptation “By believing this speech, Eve has already fallen” – Philip Gallagher The tragic weight lies in human will and agency Milton argues that temptation is necessary for freedom: “I cannot praise a fugitive and cloistered virtue” (Areopagitica)
	“but God left free the will ... Reason, is free, and Reason he made right”	Milton emphasises reason, freedom and choice Temptation is embedded in creation, but consent lies in the creature Freedom is divinely granted -seduction tests that freedom Satan is the catalyst, the necessary condition for testing

lies in Eve's agency		
----------------------	--	--

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Satan presented sympathetically Tragic/ heroic figure	“O foul decent! That I who erst contended with Gods ... am now constrain'd into a Beast”	Exclamative ‘O’ and ‘foul descent’ frame Satan in tragic terms, emphasising his fall from greatness Loss of agency invites sympathy “Readers must finally decide for themselves whether Milton satanises the epic or measures Satan against an epic standard and finds him wanting” – John Leonard
	“Revenge, at first though sweet, bitters ere long back on itself recoiles”	Satan demonstrates self-awareness, recognising the futility of revenge. This aligns him with a tragic protagonist conscious of his own suffering, rather than a purely evil figure
	“The more I see pleasures about me, so much more I feel torment within me” “Hateful siege of contraries”	Internal conflict presents Satan as psychologically complex and emotionally tortured, evoking pity William Hazlitt: “The most heroic subject that was ever chosen for a poem”
Psychological depth humanises Satan	“From inward griefe ... thus pour'd”	Emphasises internal suffering, presenting Satan as emotionally vulnerable rather than purely malicious
	“Meditated fraud and malice”	Conscious thought and deliberation and reflection, reinforcing psychological depth
	“Stupidly good”	Moment where Satan is briefly overcome by Eve's beauty – suggests he's still capable of goodness, complicating his role as absolute evil
Satan as a displaced, alienated figure	“As one who long in populous city pent ... among the pleasant villages and farmes”	The simile presents Satan as someone escaping from confinement into freedom, aligning him with a relatable human experience of longing for nature and relief
		Satan excluded from paradise
Satan as rhetorically powerful	“As when of some old Orator renowned in Athens or free Rome”	Epic simile aligns Satan with classical orators, suggesting intellectual heroism and mastery of rhetoric Nothing can exceed the energy and magnificence of the character of Satan as expressed in Paradise Lost” – Percy Shelley
	“Each act won audience ere the	Satan presented as a performer, commanding the attention of Eve and the reader,

	tongue”	charisma
Milton ultimately undercuts such heroism	“The enemie of mankind”	Reduces Satan to a moral function, stripping away individuality and heroism Explicitly positions him as the enemy

SEDUCTION

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Satan’s skilful seduction- Satan’s rhetorical campaign actively engineers Eve’s self-conception and distorts her moral framework	“Empress of this fair world” “Sovran of Creatures” “Queen of this universe”	The monarchical semantic field is deliberate excess – it flatters while quietly replacing Eden’s theocentric order with a courtly, competitive one Eve is invited to imagine herself as sovereign rather than steward – ambition is stirred first,, appetite second Milton’s Republican hostility to absolutism makes flattery a morally suspect mode of speech: Satan’s praise resembles tyrannical political sycophantic rhetoric
	“With indignation at his wrong, New part puts on” each act won audience ere the tongue”	Theatrical metaphor Satan literally adopts a role Seduction is a performance and rhetoric is a costume Milton frames temptation as a planned rhetorical campaign, not spontaneous impulse
	“Your eyes that seem so cleere, Yet are but dim, shall perfetly be then Op’nd and cleerd”	Satan destabilises perception and introduces doubt in what appears sufficient Repetition of optical language creates a semantic field of enlightenment Temptation here is framed as clarification and fulfilment He does not offer rebellion but rather improvement The future tense carries prophetic authority, he mimics divine diction
	“Strange alteration in me, to degree of Reason in my inward powers”	Satan sells sin as enlightenment by co-opting Miltonic ‘reason’ (the highest human faculty) Alteration + degree mimics the language of morals/progressive development ‘Inward powers’ gives the impression of authentic self-improvement (a persuasive

		ethos appeal) Philip Gallagher “By believing this speech, Eve has already fallen” – the fall begins at the level of assent and interpretation, not the physical bite
	“Into the Heart of Eve his words made way” “Into her heart too easy entrance won”	Milton imagines rhetoric as invasive, almost bodily force Personification gives the words themselves agency
	“Knowledge of Good and Evil; Of Good how just? Of evil, if what is evil Be real, why not known, if easier shunnd?”	Sophistry – Satan destabilises moral certainty by posing pseudo-rational questions that imply God’s command Is inconsistent Hypotactic, argumentative syntax reproduces the feel of formal disputation. The question performs reasonableness while smuggling a conclusion Classical rhetoric and Renaissance school training: argument as performance. Milton’s own polemical career makes this a self-reflexive critique of language’s power Kahn: Milton turns humanist rhetoric against itself, exposing persuasion as corruptible
	“Old some Orator renowned in Athens or free Rome”	Milton compares Satan to a classical republican orator For a poet who defended regicide and republicanism, this is charged territory The implication is that Satan’s temptation is political rhetoric Aligns with Milton’s awareness that rhetoric can be abused – especially after the collapse of the commonwealth Seduction here mirrors the persuasive power that once stirred revolution
	“Hee leading swiftly rowld In tangles, made intricate seem strait”	Serpents physical motion Temptation simplifies moral complexity He reduces the moral labyrinth into apparent clarity
	“As when a wandring fire ... misleads the amazed wanderer from his way ... there swallowed up and lost”	Epic simile equating Eve’s seduction to being led astray Will o’ the wisp Evokes folklore, false light, deceptive guidance Milton repeatedly associates Satan with perverted light, temptation appears radiant
	“As when a ship by skillful steersman wrought”	Epic similes echoing the odyssey/ the epic genre to highlight Satan’s seductive qualities

	“Joy brightens his crest” (Satan is like a soldier leading Eve)	Suggests that Satan resembles Odysseus Epic similes depict him as an epic hero
--	--	---

Seduction as mutual/ reciprocal	Quotation	Analysis
Eve self-seduction	“Eden were no Eden thus exposed”	Aphoristic language is satanic – seen in “for what God after better worse would build” or “a hell of heaven, a heaven of hell” Linguistic convergence of her and satan Eve is by no means a hollow temptress” – Jordan Seduction changes speech before it changes action Christopher ricks: “With the fall of man, language falls too”
	“Lead then, said Eve”	Eve authorises the next step Surrender Temptation requires voluntary participation This is the precise point when persuasion becomes consent
	“And what is faith, love, virtue unassayed alone without exterior help sustained” “Let us divide our labours”	Eve’s desire for isolation – isolation Is the structural precondition of the fall Seduction begins with restlessness and dissatisfaction Ambition already present Tetrachordon: “men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law” Eve’s argument resembles Milton’s belief. However Eve’s ‘transgression’ doesn’t keep the law but destroys paradise, so Milton tests the limits of his own liberty principle
	“Fruitless to me”	EVE FALLS WITH OPEN EYES Perfect beings by definition, not psychologically or dramatically or theologically satisfying that they are simply deceived, they can see the consequences but cannot

		overt it, tragic inevitability
Eve seduces Satan	"Her graceful innocence ... overawed his malice"	Seduction is reciprocal Her presence affects him, she is not merely passive Milton complicates the power dynamics
	"From every beast, more duteous at her call then at Circean call"	Prelapsarian eve already exerts influence She herself is seductive, capable of transformation McColley – Eve is "Superior to Circe" "It was Eve who tempted Satan and turned him into a serpent" – Empson (if anything, she makes him momentarily 'stupidly good')
Eve seduces Adam	"But to Adam in what sort Shall I appear? Shall I to him make known as yet my change"	Eve chooses to seduce Adam Considers her approach, strategic – satanic psychology Self-conscious performance replaces innocence She now mirrors Satan
	"How can I live without thee?" "To lose thee were to lose myself" "Not deceived, but fondly overcome with Femal charm"	Identity becomes spousal rather than theocentric – subtle idolatry Adam's uxoriousness allows him to be 'seduced' by Eve – reflecting contemporary condemnations of uxoriousness

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Milton's expansion of Genesis into psychological epic is itself a	"His fraudulent temptation thus begun"	Milton tells us that the temptation is fraudulent, then proceeds to give Satan over 100 lines of extraordinarily compelling rhetoric He grants Satan extended oratorical brilliance, comparing him to "some orator renowned in Athens or Free Rome"
	"From inward grief his	Milton seduces the reader by making Satan seem rational, thoughtful, impassioned

form of aesthetic and intellectual seduction.	bursting passion into complaints thus pour'd" "Revenge, at first though sweet, Bitter ere long back on it self back on it self recoils"	Censorship of criticism against the monarchy, is the poem itself inherently Satanic through seducing the reader? "Not a teaching but an entangling" – Stanley Fish (We the reader are seduced) Just as god places a 'provoking' object before Adam and Eve, Milton places a rhetorically compelling Satan before the reader
	"More heroic than the wrath of stern Achilles"	Milton frames the fall as epic He elevates temptation into epic grandeur That aesthetic elevation is seductive Milton's artistry mirrors the very seduction it condemns "Readers must decide for themselves whether Milton Satanises the epic or measures Satan against an epic standard and finds him wanting" – Leonard
	"And the serpent said unto the woman, Ye shall not surely die" (Genesis) vs "Do not believe those rigid threats of Death; ye shall not Die: how should ye? By the fruit? It gives you life to knowledge"	Demotic language of genesis transformed into psychologically complex and intricate argument
	"For good unknown sure is not had, or had/ and yet unknown is as not had at all" vs "she took of the fruit thereof, and did eat"	Milton gives us philosophical syllogism, epistemological reasoning, moral abstraction This psychological expansion makes the act understandable, makes Eve sympathetic, makes us inhabit her thought process We do not merely observe the fall We experience it internally
Milton's treatment of seduction operates in service of his	"So near grows death to life" (book 4) "And next to life our Death the Tree of knowledge grew fast by" (book 4)	Milton must solve the problem that if god is omnipotent and created Eden, why place a tree which would lead to corruption, sin and seduction at its centre? If temptation is structurally embedded, does that not implicate god? Temptation is spatially embedded In Areopagitica, Milton writes "God therefore left him free, set before him a provoking

overarching aim to “justify the ways of God to men”		object – Milton does not say testing but provoking. The tree stimulates desire. Temptation is constitutive of freedom and the engine of liberty. Temptation is not accidental Seduction is a structural condition of Eden itself
Milton presents Seduction as inherent and imperative	“What is faith, love, virtue, unnasayed alone without exterior help sustained”	Temptation is necessary for freedom Milton in Areopagitica: I cannot praise a fugitive and cloistered virtue” Milton presents seduction as freedom’s necessary counterpart to freedom It is permitted rather than imposed by god “By believing this speech, Eve has already fallen” – Philip Gallagher Tetrachordon: “men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law” Eve’s argument resembles Milton’s belief. However Eve’s ‘transgression’ doesn’t keep the law but destroys paradise, so Milton tests the limits of his own liberty principle
	“But God left free the will ... Reason, is free, and Reason he made right, but bid her well beware	But Milton emphasises REASON and freedom Temptation may be embedded in creation, but consent is embedded in the creature Freedom is divinely granted. Seduction tests that freedom but doesn’t override it

SIN

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
The allure of sin Sin looks magnificent but ends in fragmentation	“Fixed on the fruit she gazed, which to behold might tempt alone”	“Tempt alone” suggests sin operates independently of argument Sensory allure precedes intellectual justification Sin is embodied as beauty
	“Ye shall be as gods, knowing both good and evil”	Sin as intellectual empowerment Appeal to ambition, equality, enlightenment Echoes Genesis almost verbatim

That gap proves divine justice Through Satan's rhetoric, Milton shows the reader all the reasons why Sin has such allure – sensory, intellectually, for freedom, transcendence		Danger lies in partial truth
	“queen of this universe do not believe those rigid threats of death; ye shall not die”	Dehortatio (dissuasion) Satan's sinful rhetoric Almost echoes 10 commandments Substitutes divine command with tyrannical oppression Sin is attractive because it sounds liberating
	“As with new wine intoxicated both they swim in mirth, and fancy that they feel divinity within them”	False transcendence Illusion Sin initially feels like exaltation Blake argues that Milton even makes sin seem magnificent – the poem seems to write “at liberty when of Devils and Hell” (yet the swift collapse into cosmic ‘woe’ undercuts any sustained admiration)
	“As when a wandring fire ... misleads the amazed wanderer from his way ... there swallowed up and lost”	Epic simile equating Eve's seduction to being led astray Will o' the wisp Evokes folklore, false light, deceptive guidance Milton repeatedly associates Satan with perverted light, temptation appears radiant
	“Our days work brought to little ... th'hour of supper comes unearned”	Sin's allure begins as virtue Eve invokes ‘the parable of the talents’ Eve implicitly fears that excessive companionship and uxuriousness is a failure to maximise divine gifts – aligns with contemporary anxieties BUT this logic was used to make ambition seem virtuous Milton shows that sin does not begin as obvious rebellion Beneath this lies dissatisfaction – Milton repeatedly suggests that sin doesn't begin as grotesque desire but rather dissatisfaction Allure of self-improvement mirrors her later temptation “What hinders then to reach and feed at once both body and mind”
	“Yet not so strictly hath our lord imposed labour”	Invokes ‘parable of the vineyard’ Adam suggests that Ambition is what causes sin and that obedience matters more than productivity

		Sounds logical but this creates not ambition, but complacency But it is his stagnation and obedience – to Eve (luxuriousness) – that allows for the sin to take place “Fondly overcome with Female charm” Aligns with Augustinian theological concept of ‘disordered love’ (ordo amoris) – loving the creature above the creator Adam’s theology reflects Protestant emphasis on divine grace rather than earned salvation
--	--	---

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
The consequences of sin	“Earth felt the wound, and Nature from her seat sighing through all her works gave sign of woe”	Wound implies violence Nature responds like a living body Original sin doctrine – all creation falls
	“Nature gave a second groan”	‘Groan’ contemporary connection with childbirth Reminder of Eve’s punishment As if sin is being born into the world itself Involves us the reader in the original sin
	“Carnal desire enflaming” “In lust they burn”	Prelapsarian love was rational and balanced Now: fire imagery, hellish heat, loss of self-control Sin is degradation
	“Thus in mutual accusation spent the fruitless hours”	Relational breakdown Immediately we see blame, division The harmony of Eden collapses into discord
	“Venial discourse unblam’d: I now must change those notes to tragic”	Christopher Ricks: “With the fall of man, language falls too” Prelapsarian discourse is open, harmonious Postlapsarian language is tragic, fractured, accusatory
	“For good unknown, sure is not had” “But his forbidding commends thee more” “Our great Forbidder”	Fall of language begins when Eve speaks to herself Sounds aphoristic but is rationalisation Logic is inverted and God’s warning becomes endorsement Language is circular, non-logical now

		Blasphemous renaming Milton's portrayal of Eve's dissatisfaction aligns with Augustinian theology which locates sin not in action alone but in the inward turning of the will away from god "By believing this speech, Eve has already fallen" – Philip Gallagher
	"Soon found their eyes how opened, and their minds how darkened" vs "Divinity within them"	Knowledge produces darkness Milton makes this gap unmistakable
	"Not without song, each morning, and due praise Shall tend thee, and the fertil burden ease Of thy full branches offer'd free to all"	Reference to Adam and Eve's morning song to God Idolatry – now sings to the tree instead She unburdens the tree by eating the apples Parody of evangelising and spreading the word of God

Theme	Quotation	Analysis
Sin as structural and theological necessity Milton shows that sin is chosen, rationalised, necessary for freedom and ultimately self-destructive "Justify the ways of God to men"	"Reason he made right, but bid her well beware"	Adam articulates Milton's theology Free will entails risk Milton in book 3: "Sufficient to have stood, though free to fall" Sin is possible because freedom is god given and real John Leanord: "how can Adam and Eve be free when god foresees their every act and speaks of their fall as certainty even before It has happened"
	"The danger lies, yet lies within his power"	Sin is not externally imposed It arises from inward consent Echoes classical theological metaphor for sin: "sin is the heart curved in on itself" Stanley fish argues that the poem makes our fallenness apparent – we admire Satan, we question god, we are then corrected Sin becomes pedagogical

	“There was a place, Now not, though Sin, not Time, first wrought the change”	Milton uses sin in the epic to teach us of our fallenness Deferral of ‘now not’ emphasis on readers current state Brings us back to our reality
	“So near grows death to life” (book 4) “And next to life our Death the Tree of knowledge grew fast by” (book 4)	Milton must solve the problem that if god is omnipotent and created Eden, why place a tree which would lead to corruption, sin and seduction at its centre? If temptation is structurally embedded, does that not implicate god? Temptation is spatially embedded In Areopagitica, Milton writes “God therefore left him free, set before him a provoking object” – Milton does not say testing but provoking. The tree stimulates desire. Temptation is constitutive of freedom and the engine of liberty. Temptation is not accidental Seduction is a structural condition of Eden itself
	“What is faith, love, virtue, unassayed alone without exterior help sustained”	Temptation is necessary for freedom Milton in Areopagitica: I cannot praise a fugitive and cloistered virtue” Milton presents seduction as freedom’s necessary counterpart to freedom It is permitted rather than imposed by god “By believing this speech, Eve has already fallen” – Philip Gallagher Tetrachordon: “men of most renowned virtue have sometimes by transgressing most truly kept the law” Eve’s argument resembles Milton’s belief. However Eve’s ‘transgression’ doesn’t keep the law but destroys paradise, so Milton tests the limits of his own liberty principle
	“But God left free the will ... Reason, is free, and Reason he made right, but bid her well beware	But Milton emphasises REASON and freedom Temptation may be embedded in creation, but consent is embedded in the creature

Freedom is divinely granted. Seduction tests that freedom but doesn't override it

PLATH AND HUGHES

Theme		
Domesticity – marriage	‘Lesbos’ “In Lesbos she abandons her usual penchant for order and lets the lines stack raggedly down the page” David Trinidad – structure reflects the uncontrolled emotions in this chaotic and hostile environment. Free verse, abandons 3/4/5 line stanza characteristic structure. Long stanzas of varying lengths. Wrote the poem in the wake of the breakdown of her relationship with Hughes while staying with the Kanes in Cornwall, a couple with whom she had ambivalent feelings. Criticism of Kathy Kane – striking meditation on the roles women are expected to fill, the hostility it breeds between women. Title: immediately introduces notion of sisterhood and female solidarity. “The potatoes hiss” “The fluorescent light wincing on and off like a terrible migraine.” – animates the kitchen space with an almost hostile energy. Intense sensory language. Harsh, cold, and clinical environment evoked rather than the warmth frequently associated with	‘Her Husband’ Mutual resentment that can develop between people under the pressures of domestic responsibilities – between a couple rather than between women. Stark, unsentimental depiction of marriage. Domestic world shaped by economic hardship. Hughes strips the romanticism from marriage, depicted it instead as a transactional, dehumanising institution. “A poem of domestic bitterness. (...) The man and the woman are permanently separated ... [they are] stock characters, and their relationships is part of the standard love story of poverty.” - Maggie Dickie Uroff – not a poem meant to antagonise either person, but rather to shed light on both sides of the domestic experience. 3rd person voice – distance and detachment, mimicking that felt within the relationship. “Let her learn with scrubbing brush and scrubbing board the stubborn character of money” - plosive alliteration, violent and almost aggressive. Immediately introduces that this is a hostile domestic environment.

domestic environments.

Demonstrates how the domestic environment can be painful and uncomfortable.

Presents motherhood in twisted, pessimistic way:

“Where they crap and puke and cry and she can’t hear.”

- polysyndetic list creates a sense of accumulation and overwhelm. Blunt visceral words. Evokes the raw, unglamorous realities of motherhood. Commentary on how motherhood is romanticised

The speaker imagines a world where they “should meet in another life, we should meet in air, me and you.” a

fantasy of a paradise, like Lesbos the Greek island

Suggests that the only place for female kinship and freedom is in an entirely imagined world outside of the domestic sphere

Triplet, rhyme: “hair” “affair” and “air” – poetically contrived and rigidly constructed, fantasy

“Sylvia Plath’s ‘Lesbos’ powerfully presents the island as an unreachable ideal place, the counterpart to everything that is wrong with real women’s lives.” – Emily Wilson

“It is love you are full of. You know who you hate.” –

chiasmus of love and hate, shows how marriage can warp a relationship, thin line between love and hate.

The ‘hate’ and ‘gate’ rhyme of the following line creates a sense of entrapment as if marriage and the domestic life is imprisoning.

Poem ends with chilling, vindictive line: “even in your zen heaven we shan’t meet” – not about religion or secularity, rather a commentary on the performative

Harsh physicality of the woman’s domestic rite. The monetary hardship is inextricably linked to physical labour – both her and her husband’s. Evokes the monotony of housework.

However, the heavy dental alliteration of the opening lines evokes the exhaustion of the husband, creating pathos and sympathy for him. “Dull with coal-dust deliberately” – Hughes paints a world caked in industrial grime. Terse and compact phrase.

“Let her learn through what kind of dust he has earned his thirst ... what sweat he has exchanged for his money.” – money is not a symbol of success but of bodily degradation.

“Earned” is bitterly ironic, what he earns through backbreaking labour is not rest or satisfaction, but thirst.

“Exchanged” – sacrifice, his sweat for currency, commodification of the working-class body. Tonally bitter, dehumanising.

“Blood-weight of money” – not just earned through labour but bled for – there is something morally compromised and bodily costly about it. Monosyllables of blood and weight feel heavy, echoing that money as an oppressive force in their marriage.

Hughes turns money into a visceral antagonist.

“He’ll humble her” – suggests he exerts dominance not just economically but emotionally and physically. Chilling simplicity. Disturbing connotations of

	domestic life that the female companion leads and the falsehood of it. Impossibility of unity between these women. Both critiques the patriarchal system that forces women into these positions and conforms to it, by criticising her female companion for not meeting their standards. Plath separating from Hughes, poem not really a criticism of Kathy Kane at all, projection of her own marriage insecurities onto the couple as a way to release her anger. Contrary to Edward Butscher's view that the poem is 'whining decked out as art' and its personal nature, it is also universal in its depiction of stifling, suffocating domesticity.	submission, humiliation, and even violence. "Women were still economically dependent on their husbands" even by the end of the 1970s – Amy Worcester "For they have their rights. Their jurors are to be assembled. Their brief goes straight up to heaven" 'Rights' 'jurors' 'brief' The suggestion is that although they may have rights, they are passed "up to heaven" where real justice is never realised. Hughes highlights the emptiness of institutional promises. Heaven here is not a source of salvation but a filing cabinet for the working class's grievances. Their suffering is institutionally erased – their love story isn't unique, but one of systemic invisibility and class struggle. "for they will have their rights is definitive" – acknowledges divorce as a possibility but doesn't celebrate it. 1960s divorce became increasingly common and established new hope for women. However, "the rise of divorces saw the rise of paranoia around the institution of marriage." – Amy Worcester on marriage in the 60s and 70s
Domesticity - parenthood	'you're' "By candlelight" can be read as [an example] of maternal ambivalence in its primary sense: the coexistence of tender feelings with the resentment of being entrapped by one's condition. - Alice Braun (this could be better applied to Edge/ you're)	'Full moon and Little Frieda' Diana Middlebrook calls 'full moon and little Frieda' "a poetic reply" to Morning Song Celebration of childhood innocence and wonder "Cool small evening" - metaphorical smallness shows how ordinary of a night it is and therefore sets the stage

“Pregnancy makes the body strange and foreign.” - Katherine Robinson on ‘Nick and the Candlestick’

“You’re Clownlike, happiest on your hands,” - aspirant alliteration evokes breathless happiness, playful/whimsical language evokes excitement
“Feet to the stars” - idea of fate, suggests that she feels she was destined to be a mother
Mention of “dodo” evokes something more primal suggesting that the baby is keen to live with this playful rejection of extinction.

Plath wrote in journal: “For a woman to be deprived of the Great Experience her body is formed to partake of, to nourish, is a great and wasting death.” - fate, giving birth is destiny fulfilled, completes her purpose as a woman.

“Wrapped up in yourself like a spool,” - undertone of anxiety, image of umbilical cord, idea of threads unwinding, fragile and delicate
“Bent-backed Atlas” idea of burden to the baby with this classical allusion of carrying an extreme weight. Great responsibility that comes with being a mother

“A Mexican bean” - foreignness, detachment, as if the mother doesn’t feel completely connected to the baby
Diane Middlebrook - this poem expresses a parent’s feelings of anxious alienation from the infant.
“A clean slate, with your own face on” - sense of anxiety but also hope that her child will be separate from her trauma.

for how children find beauty and awe in the simple and ordinary and therefore elicit the same reaction in their watching parents.

The metaphors of blood and milk recall birth and babyhood, “unspilled milk” suggests tension and potential, mimicking the potential a young child has, to experience the world for the first time.
“Moon! Moon” - sudden exclamation breaks the tension and shows how just like the moon, Frieda is an everyday miracle and her excitement at seeing it in turn awakens Hughes to both wonders.
Her urgent repetition conveys her awe through the toddler-like speech. (MOON SYMBOLISM)

Image of moon as “an artist” stepping back and “gazing amazed” creates a sense of awe and wonder reflecting back and forth between Frieda, the moon, and also Hughes.
The diacope of “amazed” underscores the mutual surprise and delight.
The artist moon becomes an image of Hughes himself, as he created Frieda, amazed at his daughter’s own amazement and existence.

	Two stanzas of 9 lines - self-contained image of the nine months of pregnancy, as if the poem tells the story of a pregnancy that starts with total excitement but becomes more worrisome as anxiety creeps in.	
	Both depicts the joy and excitement to be found in becoming a parent. However, Plath depicts an anxiety that Hughes does not, an anxiety in the responsibility that comes with parenthood	
Violence and brutality	‘Cut’ - historical and personal violence Comments on the glorification of historic violence and its lasting impacts on people “A flap like a hat” – unexpected, almost playful comparison creates discomfort by trivialising the wound, highlighting the banality if violence, an idea credited to Hannah Ardent in her book <i>The Banality of Evil</i> (1961) Re-emphasised in juvenile register of “Whose side are they on?” “Redcoats” and the American war for independence is seen as a thrilling game rather than a tragedy. Rhyme of “I am ill. I have taken a pill to kill” – gives impression of a kind of childish chant or nursery rhyme, how we underplay the significance of acts of violence. Similar effect with sing-song rhythm of “A million soldiers run, redcoats, every one.” Deborah Nelson: “the poem explores the way war and violence become banal and morally ambiguous.” “Your turkey wattle” interwoven with extremely violent images “The Indian’s axed your scalp” – relates brutality to an image of Thanksgiving and celebration, directly criticising his historic American violence is honoured in the name of patriotism rather than being recognised for	‘Hawk Roosting’ – violence as a fundamental, neutral force of nature ML Rosenthal: no other poet managed to describe “the murderousness of nature through such brilliantly objective means” “My hooked head and hooked feet” – aspirant alliteration and guttural sounds emphasises the sharpness of the creature’s weapons. Designed to kill and fulfil its predatory purpose. “The air’s buoyancy and the sun’s ray are of advantage to me” – ecstatic, nature is set up perfectly so he can kill Air allows the hawk to fly, the sun allows it to see its prey Nature is entirely indifferent to its violence and allows, even encourages, it to happen The enjambment here creates a sense of breezy easiness, mimicking how the hawk can fly wherever it wants “It took the whole of Creation to produce my foot, my each feather.” – divine right to kill, natural, ‘Creation’ is capitalised alluding to the Christian creation myth, hawk has a mandate from God as a predator to inflict violence and kill The hawk sees himself as the pinnacle of the evolutionary process.

	the devastation it was. The loaded image of “The stain on your gauze Klu Klux Klan” – refers to the white hoods of white supremacist organisation founded in 1865. Image would’ve been especially associated with a very present violence for readers as, at the time Plath was writing, the third clan was opposing the civil rights movement in the 60s and committing savage racist attacks. The image of the gauze creates the sense of an attempt to mask and hide the violence but the blood shows through anyways. Combined with the poem’s historic references moving from past present creates the idea that the guilt and shame of American violence is generational and ignoring it or worse, celebrating it, only allows it to continue. Deborah Nelson: “dissociates the speaker from the injury” allowing the poem to “explore the anaesthetising effects of spectatorship.” – perhaps the poem is intentionally distant to show how ignorance and dismissiveness towards the violence in our history can facilitate further violence and being a spectator can desensitise us to the tragedy. “Dirty girl” – intense shame the speaker has due to the violence in her nation’s history making her feel dirty and polluted. She wants to cleanse herself and purge herself of the guilt and in a way, this is exactly what the poem is meant to be for the speaker, an act of catharsis.	“There is no sophistry in my body: My manners are tearing off heads.” – ‘Sophistry’ and ‘manners’ belong to human notions of morality which don’t apply to nature. Violence is just as much a part of nature as beauty, violence and innocence in the natural world at least, coexist in balance. “Tearing off heads” – brutality makes it a stark and shocking moment, violence may be ugly and brutal, but it isn’t wrong or unnatural. John Press “pummels his readers with the harshest, most solid words in order to batter them into submission” Alan Brownjohn: “Raw sex-and-violence imagery” Hughes has been criticised for being deliberately hyperbolic and brutal, but perhaps it is too easy to read this poem in this way. Hughes simply presents us with the violence that does exist in the natural world, without providing an opinion on whether it is good or bad. In this way, his descriptions are potentially mimetic, and the aforementioned critics fall into the trap of imposing human frameworks of morality onto nature where they simply don’t apply. Fashion for artistic depictions of violence following war, influenced by artworks like Picasso’s ‘Guernica’ which plainly and brutally expresses war’s violence. George Steiner asserts that Plath’s poem is the ‘Guernica of modern poetry’
Violence and brutality –	‘The stones’ – human response to brutality Delves into the aftermath of brutality, reconstruction	‘Snowdrop’ – nature’s response to brutality Explores the universal struggle to survive

effects	after destruction Begins with an image of stasis introspection, creating a sense of being trapped in an alien world. Imagery of an anvil suggests a brutal process of reshaping or forging, setting the tone for dehumanising reconstruction "Sky-circle" – evokes a surreal detachment. "This is the after-hell" – suggests that she's been through hell and violence and now is on the other side. But this other side is a form of hell itself. Semantic field of medical imagery: 'food tubes' 'pincers' 'Stitches my fissures' 'doctor heads' – poem takes place in a hospital. In 1958 Plath and Hughes moved to Boston and Plath took a part time job at a hospital, perhaps In this poem she imagines herself as one of the people she may have encountered. Tension between deconstruction and reconstruction is introduced with numerous images of both mending and fragmentation/decomposition. Speaker's fissures are stitched, her legs are swaddled, "food tubes embrace" her, "sponges" "kiss" her "lichens away". These clinical images of construction and mending are both positive as she's being fixed and sinister as we get the sense that these things are being done to her and she's completely powerless: "There is nothing to do" Healing is an ambivalent thing – not always positive and can sometimes, especially when its being done to	"Now the globe shrunk tight/ Round the mouse's dulled wintering heart" – combination of micro and macro cosmic imagery creates a sense of asphyxiation and contraction while the assonance gives the line a soporific quality. The enjambment of the lines also subtly evokes the constriction as the first line seems to exert its grip around the following. Weasel and crow described as moving "as if moulded in brass" – movements appear heavy and stiff from the cold. The use of manmade imagery when describing nature also creates a sense of the industrial brutality of winter. Nature in this poem changes in response to the harsh environment and becomes harder and stiffer. "She too pursues her ends" – exposes ultimately hopeful attitude, that the tulip will endure the effects of violence that the natural world imposes and due to its ability to adapt, it survives the harshness of winter in the end. "Her pale head hangs heavy as metal" – violence engenders more violence in the natural world, this quality of nature, its resilience and ability to survive in the face of such brutality, which makes it so powerful. Encourages resilience as a response.
---------	--	--

	you by others, feel invasive and unwanted. abundance of reconstructive images and the poem looking at first glance on paper with its even stanza lengths, a very whole and rounded poem upon deeper inspection it's actually fragmented and riddled with images of decomposition with the tercets leaving hollowness and blankness on the page and a sense of needing to be fixed. "City of spare parts" where "dead men leave eyes for others" – reduces humanity to interchangeable components, stripping away individuality. The commodification of body parts reflects a dehumanised view of identity. "There is nothing to do. I shall be good as new." – ironic as the speaker is not good as new but put back together, this time with flaws, cracks, and evidence of being broken. Conveys how it's devastating to survive as you're left with mendings, a symbol of being healed but also a constant reminder of once being broken.	
Death – not a tragedy	'Edge' Opens with "the woman is perfected. /Her dead/body wears the smile of accomplishment" - poem equates death with perfection and the slant rhyme of "perfected" and "dead" reinforces this idea. The stark enjambment after "dead" also emphasises its finality, dismissing any idea of life after death. Could also be an ironic comment on how a patriarchal society imposes such impossible standards on women that they feel they can only be perfect in death.	'Hawk Roosting' Hawk given the powers of English, views death as unremarkable and a common, innate part of nature. "Hooked head and hooked feet" - aspirant alliteration and guttural sounds emphasise the sharpness of the creature's killing weapons Hawk is designed perfectly to kill and to fulfil its predatorial purpose "The air's buoyancy and the sun's ray are of advantage to me" - ecstatic, nature is set up perfectly so that he can

Considering that this was the last poem Plath wrote before her suicide, the sinister “smile of accomplishment” that evokes a sense of pride and celebration, as if the woman was responsible for her own death, is especially significant.

This allusion to suicide within the poem means it could be somewhat semi-autobiographical, and a representation of the way Plath feels about death.

Wears “The illusion of Greek necessity.” - ironises the idea of Greek tragic fate where someone has an untimely death because it was decreed by the gods and therefore inescapable. Because it is only “the illusions” the speaker understands it was by choice rather than fate.

“Refuses to affirm the ... existence of the divine” – Constance Scheerer

Poem’s form is somewhat restrained and careful, with the brevity and abundance of negative space while the third person perspective creates distance, affording the poem an observational and almost relaxed quality, something unusual compared to Plath’s normal confessionalism style.

Despite the dark topic of death, the voice isn’t particularly emotional, conveying the woman’s calm attitude towards death.

Describes the children as “a white serpent” - predatory, introduces idea of the pressure of motherhood and hints that this may have been a reason for the woman’s death - **Genesis context**

“Pitcher of milk” is “now empty” - mother’s breast with

kill

Air allows the hawk to fly, and the sun allows him to see his pray

Nature is entirely indifferent to death and allows, even encourages, it to happen.

The enjambment here creates a sense of breezy easiness, mimicking how the hawk can fly wherever he wants.

“It took the whole of Creation to produce my foot, my each feather.” - divine right to kill, natural, ‘Creation’ is capitalised alluding to the Christian creation myth, hawk has a mandate from God as a predator to kill

The hawk sees himself as the pinnacle of the evolutionary process.

Darwinism, Tennyson’s ‘red in tooth and claw’

“There is no sophistry in my body: my manners are tearing off heads.” - ‘sophistry’ and ‘manners’ belong to human notions of morality which don’t apply to nature.

The balance of the natural world seems infinitely complex to humanity, but it is remarkably simple: there is predator and prey and no such thing as good or evil.

The brutality of “tearing off heads” - stark and shocking moment, while death may be ugly and brutal, it isn’t wrong or unnatural.

“Simply Nature” – Hughes

“Only human beings can imagine death and thus glory in it” – Herbert Lomas

	no more milk left for breastfeeding, being a mother has drained her and now she has nothing left to give to her children. "She has folded them back into her body." - strange reversal of an image of birth, act of uncreation just like death is, however it is gentle and comforting here, image of death as something that isn't always tragic "At home, all I ever saw was the <i>Christian Science Monitor</i>, which appeared on the doorstep at five o'clock every day but Sunday and treated suicides and" – The Bell Jar	
Death – inevitability	'Death & Co.' Plath critiques the average persons fear of death by contrasting their views of death in the first half of the poem with her own at the end. Speaker describes on of two figures of death, the one that most people see: "The one who never looks up, whose eyes are lidded and balled, like Blake's" - direct reference to William Blake's plaster life cast of his head, creates a cold and lifeless image with the permanently 'lidded' eyes alluding to eternal sleep rather than any kind of afterlife. Represents how many people think that death is a lonely, hollow state of complete stillness, as if your body becomes a lifeless cast of what it once was. "I am red meat. His beak clasps sidewise." - vulturine image, with death as a predator, humanity its prey, parodies how we think that death is always after us and critiques the idea of living in fear of death coming after	'Examination at Womb-door' Hughes comments on Death's looming presence. Even before the poem begins, death is always lingering in the background, even with the choice of a crow as one of the main subjects of the poem – Poem also features in a collection titled 'Crow' – Crows are often associated with death and the gothic. First Stanza, lexical field of images that convey the frailty of the physical body: "scrawny" "bristly" "still-working" "questionable" – sense of doubt in the ability of the physical body to beat death Enhanced by the anaphora and abundance of questions which contribute to a sense of commodification of the body and death's ultimate ownership over life "Given, stolen, or held pending trial? Held." – legalistic language conveys an uncertainty and tentative quality, suggesting the idea that death could happen at any moment. Word 'held' alludes to Christian idea of purgatory, portraying death as a place of solitude and suspension

	us. As Plath moves onto discuss the second figure of death after the Volta, the portrayal becomes almost ridiculous “Masturbating a glitter” - ‘masturbating’ is the antithesis of new life, its potential that ends up amounting to nothing. ‘Glitter’ - somewhat celebratory and uncomfortably playful Speaker finding some kind of perverse pleasure in death Arthur h. Oberg - “There is an insistence here that borders on obsession and hysteria” - kind of hysterical element to this poem, as if the speaker is ecstatic about the idea of death, line “He wants to be loved” certainly has a very affectionate tone. “Somebody’s done for” - ends with blunt line, so far death has been completely mystified and unknowable, associated with all kinds of juxtaposing images, however, with this final line we finally get some certainty. Dull, insipid climax - tells us that the only thing we know for sure is that death is guaranteed and so beyond that, there’s no point in trying to understand or grapple with the concept. Telling us to accept that its coming and live or lives in spite of it anyways.	Certainty of death without the reassurance that Plath provides “Who owns the whole rainy, stony earth? Death” – indirectly alludes to Genesis 26 except instead of the earth being owned by man, it’s owned by death. Certainty in God is replaced by certainty in death. “Death is the sole owner of the universe, stronger than hope, will, love, or life.” – Margaret Dickie Uroff This idea is conveyed in the final stanza where the epiphora creates a sense of accumulation and crescendo in death’s power where with each line it seems to get more and more powerful. However, this is obliterated by the final “but” where the dramatic cut to the tension is ironised with the crow claiming to be more powerful than death. This bathos highlights the absolute ridiculousness of anything thinking itself to be more powerful than death.
Death – romanticised vs brutalised	‘Ariel’ Plath presents death as ecstatic, aestheticised and almost transcendent, blurring liberation with self-annihilation Warren: Plath is “driven by a death wish”	‘View of a pig’ Hughes presents death as brutal, undignified and anti-romantic “It was too dead” – blunt, monosyllabic, strips death of

“Stasis in darkness” – poem opens in paralysis, but rapidly accelerates into movement, suggesting death as an escape from bodily and psychological entrapment

“God’s lioness,/How one we grow” – biblical/mythic register elevates the ride beyond ordinary experience. The fusion of rider and horse suggests the dissolution of individual identity; death is romanticised as a moment of sublime unity

“And now i/ Foam to wheat, a glitter of seas” – enjambment mirrors acceleration. ‘Foam’ suggests dissolution while ‘glitter’ aestheticises the speaker’s disintegration, making death beautiful rather than grotesque

“White/Godiva, I unpeel -/ dead hands, dead stringencies” – Lady Godiva allusion frames the speaker as rebellious and heroic. Unpeel suggests shedding restrictive identities, repetition of dead suggests such a fascination, implies that liberation requires a symbolic or literal death

“Suicidal, at one with the drive” – explicit connection between motion, freedom and death. The adjective is shocking, but the syntax makes the self-destruction seem purposeful, even empowered

Kendall: “motion is almost always positive” in Plath’s poems

mystery and transcendence. The phrase is almost absurdly plain, refusing any spiritual consolation

First two stanzas are heavily end-stopped, creating a sense of finality and lifeless weight
The repeated ‘it’ anaphora objectifies the pig, reducing it to an item, clinical precision

“Such weight and thick pink bulk” – plosive consonants and heavy monosyllables emphasise the sheer materiality of the corpse. Death is not release but mass, flesh and heaviness. Denies the possibility of a noble death

“I thumped it without feeling remorse” – the speaker’s emotional detachment is disturbing. Hughes presents a desensitised response to death, as if the corpse is too physically dead to inspire pity

“Just so much/ A poundage of lard and pork” – economic language reduces the animal to a commodity. Death erases individuality and turns the body into consumable matter

“Of earthly pleasure as it had been, seemed a false effort” – even the pig’s former life is retrospectively dismissed. Death makes life appear ridiculous and futile

“It’s squeal was the rending of metal” – harsh industrial imagery. The pig’s suffering is not lyrical but grating, mechanical and brutal

	“Into the red/Eye, the cauldron of morning” – may symbolise sunrise and rebirth but ‘cauldron’ evokes combustion and sacrifice. The split across the line break isolates ‘red’ connoting blood and violence before resolution Plath writes purely for herself Death is linked to movement and speed Plath aestheticises self-destruction through glittering, elemental imagery	Desensitised audience that Hughes is writing to Death is linked to weight and stillness Hughes strips death of symbolism, forcing the reader to confront the flesh itself
Nature – brutality	‘Tulips’ Nature completely incongruous to the setting “Too excitable” amongst the bleak, clinical environment of a hospital. The iambic pentameter of sections of the poem and the militaristic feel it evokes illustrates the order and control within the hospital environment that stands in stark contrast to the uncontrollability and unpredictability of nature. This juxtaposition serves to demonstrate the resilience of nature to conformity, however, Plath doesn’t see this as positive and instead resents the tulips for their relentlessness and glaring light amongst all the bleakness. Describes a dialogue between her blood and the tulips: “their redness speaks to my wound” – the tulips’ colour mirrors that of the speaker’s blood, except for the tulips, this connection comes from health and life whereas from the speaker it comes from a wound.	‘Snowdrop’ Nature’s response to brutality, admiration Explores the universal struggle to survive “Now the globe shrunk tight/ Round the mouse’s dulled withering heart” – combination of micro and microcosmic imagery creates a sense of asphyxiation and contraction while the assonance gives the line a soporific quality Enjambment of the lines also subtly evokes the constriction as the first line seems to exert its grip around the following. Weasel and crow described as moving “as if moulded in brass” – animals’ movements appear heavy and stiff from the cold Use of manmade imagery when describing nature creates a sense of the industrial brutality of winter. “She too pursues her ends” – exposes ultimately hopeful attitude of the poem Due to the snowdrop’s ability to adapt, it makes it out

	The tulips' abundance of life makes the speaker's lifelessness all the more apparent "They seem to float, though they weigh me down." – tulips' ability to persevere exposes the speakers' inability to do so herself. Plath "contrasts the seductively anaesthetic blankness of the hospital with the 'sudden tongues' of the red flowers, which hurt the speaker back to life." – Christina Britzolakis - Perhaps the extreme contrast does hurt the speaker, it does not bring them back to life and rather it makes her feel despondent and hopeless Sense of competition between the speaker and the tulips: "the vivid tulips eat my oxygen" – image of survival of the fittest, resource battles that occur in primal nature As if the only other living thing in the hospital environment, the tulips automatically become her enemy Uncanny tension, tulips become predatory.	and survives the harshness of winter in the end. "Her pale head hangs heavy as metal" – encapsulates how violence engenders more violence in the natural world. It is this quality of nature, its resilience and ability to survive against all odds, that makes it so powerful.
	Hughes: somewhat hopeful, admiring nature's ability to adapt to harsh circumstances and endure through brutality Plath: finds this quality of nature jarring in the way it reveals her own weaknesses	
Nature – vs man	'Wuthering Heights' Plath finds nature alienating and depressing. Nature is cold and apathetic and humans with all our Romantic notions can't seem to grasp that nature doesn't care about us. "The horizons ring me like faggots," – creates a sense of claustrophobia, as if the speaker is simultaneously trapped and separated. Subverts the idea of Romantic	'Pike' Hughes finds nature's violence awe-inspiring and significant "Malevolent aged grin" and "Jaws hooked clamp and fangs" – depicts nature as inherently evil and violent, reminiscent of Tennyson's famous description of nature as "red in tooth and claw". Hughes superimposes human notions of binary morality

isolationism where romantics think you have revelatory encounters with nature when you go out on your own.

Here, the speaker seems to tell us that that's completely delusional and nature is ruthless and dangerous and doesn't care about you and being alone in nature is alienating and entrapping.

Title – blurs the line between true nature and our pre-conceived notions by drawing on a sense of familiarity – using the well known novel by Emily Brontë 'Wuthering Heights'. Blurs the line between a fictionalised and real landscape, creating a sense of disorientation and unease.

"Evaporates" "Solider" "Dissolve" – combination of images of solidity and dissolution in the first stanza creates a paradox between the two states, adding to a sense of unease and impermanence amongst nature.

Furthered, tension reflected in both the form and rhythm:

"But they only dissolve and dissolve" – **anapestic rhythm** mimics the images of collapse and formation **the line lengths in the first stanza which concaves and convenes evokes the un-forming and reforming and impermanence of the ever-changing landscape before the speaker.**

Creates a sense of instability and chaos between man and nature, building tension of not knowing what's to come next

onto the natural world, describing something as categorically good or bad.

Hughes also takes a **Darwinian view of nature**, describing it as **"killers from the egg"** – completely subverts the idea of childhood innocence and implies that nature and animals are innately aggressive and violent.

Abundance of enjambment in the ending of the poem creates a sense of anticipation and tension as if something's about to happen. However, this is also somewhat ironic because the speaker could easily be waiting for something that might not ever happen. This plays on the **Romantic idea of a revelatory encounter with nature**, exposing how its naïve to impose significance on an everyday phenomenon or to think that yourself and nature have any kind of significant relationship.

"Outlasted every visible stone/ of the monastery" – nature's superiority over humanity, a symbol of religious belief has been broken down but nature still endures.

Darwinian perspective conveys the idea of human insignificance and man's belief systems and moral frameworks being intruders to the natural world.

"Pushing of the sublime into the brutal" – John Kinsella

	“The house lights gleam like small change” – ‘house lights’ symbolically represent human consciousness, has ‘small change’ – shows how inferior human civilisation is and how pointless it is to think that we can understand or even control nature. “The sky leans on me, me.” – playful repetition of ‘me’ satirises and subverts the notion of the Romantic hero who has a unique and personal experience with nature. The speaker reminds us of nature’s indifference “Rejects the romantic celebration of unity with nature” – Eileen M. Aird	
Liberation/ transcendence	‘Ariel’ Transcendence is presented as both ecstatic liberation and self-annihilation The poem opens in darkness – “Stasis in darkness” – suggesting paralysis before transformation Simple syntax create immobile feel with abstract noun ‘stasis’ suggesting emotional and creative blockage as well as just literal Darkness is not merely physical but psychological The caesura isolates the phrase, mirroring suspension before movement “These new poems of mine have one thing in common. They were all written at about four in the morning – that still, blue, almost eternal hour before cock-crows, before the baby’s cry, before the glassy music of the milkman setting his bottles” The ride becomes a metaphor for artistic and spiritual release The kinetic verbs – “pour of tor and distances” “Splits and passes” – create forward propulsion, mimicking the	‘Jaguar’ Hughes presents transcendence as psychological defiance rather than self-erasure The zoo animals are initially characterised with lethargy (first half): “the apes yawn and adore their fleas in the sun” – long vowel sounds immediately drain the energy out of the first line (inertia echoed in the assonance) The syllabic verse, anaphoric, end-stops and enclosed rhyme (“nut” “Strut”) of the first stanza create a mundane, uniform feeling, caged quality Parrots “Strut like cheap tarts” humiliating degradation, reducing them to prostitution, begging for attention and food “It might be painted on a nursery wall” – wild creatures becomes so one dimensional in this zoo that they may as well be drawings, romanticised, censored Second half of poem shifts focus to the jaguar “By the bang of blood in the brain” – plosive alliteration, power and violence, syntax breaks down

gallop itself

“**Gods lioness/ How one we grow**” – biblical register elevates the ride to a mythic scale. Lioness connotes power and predatory grace, but also danger – introducing the poem’s key tension

The syntactic fusion of ‘one we grow’ collapses subject boundaries – rider and horse merge. Transcendence here is annihilation of the separate self

Momentum then erupts: “**and now I/ Foam to wheat, a glitter of seas**”

Enjambment propels the line forward, mimicking the horse’s acceleration

‘Foam’ suggests dissolution – the speaker becomes formless energy rather than stable identity

‘Glitter of seas’ introduces vast, macrocosmic, elemental imagery; transcendence is oceanic and boundary-dissolving

Yet this liberation is violent: “**White/Godiva, I unpeel-/ dead hands, dead stringencies**”

The allusion to lady Godiva invokes rebellion, saviour figure who rides naked through the streets

‘Unpeel’ suggests shedding social constraints and ‘white’ connotes purity, rebirth

But the harsh dental consonants in ‘dead’ and ‘stringencies’ emphasise that liberation requires stripping away restrictive identities – possibly even life itself

“**Into the red/Eye, the cauldron of morning**” – may symbolise sunrise and rebirth but ‘cauldron’ evokes combustion and sacrifice. The split across the line break isolates ‘red’ connoting blood and violence before

(lack of an object), freedom

“**He spins from the bars but there’s no cage to him**” – conjunction pivots from physical confinement to metaphysical freedom. Internal rhyme of ‘spins’ and ‘him’ create circularity – his energy is self-sustaining The paradox ‘no cage to him’ as well as “more than a visionary to his cell” suggests that he transcends his captivity with his mind

“**The world rolls under the long thrust of his heel**” – rolls implies cosmic motion, the jaguar becomes axis mundi. Unlike Plath’s dissolution of self, Hughes’ transcendence expands identity

‘Thrust’ conveys phallic power and assertion

Final line “**over the cage floor the horizons come**” – image of hope embedded into the cage floor, the world is at his feet

Hart: “Hughes identified with the predatory animals themselves”

	resolution The transcendence culminates in incineration Plath's liberation is double-edged – an ecstatic freedom that may also be self-destruction. Transcendence becomes indistinguishable from obliteration Ariel in the tempest: Shakespeare's 'airy spirit', a symbol of imagination, transcendence and creativity, enslaved by prospero Written on Plath's 30th birthday, October 27th 1962 – poem carries autobiographical urgency. Hughes: "Ariel was the name of the horse on which she went riding weekly ... her horse bolted, the stirrups fell off, and she came all the way home to the stables, about two miles, at full gallop, hanging around the horses neck. – links transcendence to real physical risk	
Transcendence	'Mirror' "I am silver and exact. I have no preconceptions" – blunt declarative syntax and monosyllabic certainty establish a voice of clinical precision. "Locating the centre of consciousness in the mirror isolates the woman" – van dyne – makes the woman an object of scrutiny rather than subject, preventing her transcendence 'Silver' connotes sterility and coldness, while 'exact' suggests mathematical objectivity The mirror rejects transcendence entirely – it claims to reflect without interpretation, a flat material surface devoid of spiritual elevation	'Football at slack' Hughes transforms an everyday football match into a moment of quasi-romantic sublimity, elevating the every day into something mythic and transcendent The setting immediately expands the everyday into vastness: "between plunging valleys, on a bareback of hill" 'Plunging' gives the valleys violent motion The phrase 'bareback of hill' anthropomorphises the landscape, turning geography into living anatomy The football match isn't enclosed like Plath's mirror – it is exposed to elemental grandeur

“Whatever I see I swallow immediately” – verb ‘swallow’ suggests mechanical ingestion
No transformative process – no alchemy of perception into meaning. Experience is consumed and reproduced instantly
“I am not cruel, only truthful” unlike Hughes’ celebratory sublime, Plath’s truth is anti-romantic. The mirror offers no consolation, no aesthetic distance. Reality Is unmediated and unforgiving.

When the perspective shifts – “now I am a lake” – this could suggest potential transcendence, as lakes in romantic poetry often symbolise depth and reflection. However the lake here does not liberate.

“A woman bends over me,/ searching my reaches for what she really is” – enjambment mirrors the woman’s leaning posture, but the verb ‘searching’ implies anxiety rather than revelation.

There is no epiphany, she doesn’t find transcendence, instead she finds decay

“In me she has drowned a young girl, and in me an old woman/ Rises toward her day after day, like a terrible fish”

Violent verb ‘drowned’ suggests that youth has been killed by time’s reflection. The simile “like a terrible fish” is bathetic, grotesque and anti-sublime.

Instead of a beautiful metamorphosis, ageing becomes monstrous

The clinical ‘day after day’ reinforces inevitability, there is no spiritual transcendence – only the relentless progression of time

“The merry-coloured men spouted like water to head it”

The verb ‘spouted’ turn the players into fountains or geysers

The simile dissolves the solidity of the body – they become an elemental force

The game transcends sport and becomes ritualistic movement with nature

“The glare light/mixed its mad oils and threw glooms” =

the synaesthetic image of light mixing oils invokes artistic creation – the sky becomes a cosmic canvas
Chaotic brilliance

Unlike Plath’s sterile silver, Hughes’ light is volatile and generative

“And once again a golden holocaust/lifted the cloud’s edge, to watch them” – oxymoronic pairing of beauty

and destruction suggests overwhelming cosmic power
The sun becomes a conscious observer – this everyday match is witnessed by a celestial force

Human action momentarily participates in something mythic

Personal experience/ confessionalism	‘Ariel’ Plath presents the creative process as intensely personal, bodily and existential. The poem reads like an enacted experience rather than a detached reflection. The poem opens in paralysis – “Stasis in darkness” ‘Stasis’ suggests emotional and creative blockage. The darkness is psychological as much as literal. Creativity begins not in inspiration, but in inertia – a recognisably personal struggle. These new poems of mine have one thing in common. They were all written at about four in the morning – that still, blue, almost eternal hour before cock-crows, before the baby’s cry, before the glassy music of the milkman setting his bottles” The ride becomes a metaphor for artistic and spiritual release The kinetic verbs – “pour of tor and distances” “Splits and passes” – create forward propulsion, mimicking the gallop itself but also the propulsion towards creation “And now i/foam to wheat, a glitter of seas” – the enjambment mimics acceleration. The speaker dissolves into foam – no longer a stable identity but kinetic energy. This reflects the loss of ego in creative immersion. Unlike Hughes’ careful metaphorical shaping, Plath’s syntax feels breathless and uncontained. “Suicidal, at one with the drive” Startling adjective. Creative ‘drive’ aligns with self-destructive impulse. Reflects the extremity of	‘The thought-fox’ In contrast, Hughes represents the creative process through metaphor and mythic mediation. But has a mythic/symbolic distance from the poem itself “I imagine this midnight moment’s forest” – verb ‘imagine’ foregrounds consciousness, yet the forest suggests subconscious depth. The tone is controlled and observational rather than immersed. Inspiration appears tentatively – “a fox’s nose touches twig, leaf” Careful monosyllables mimic delicate emergence. Creativity is incremental, not explosive. The fox is encountered here, not embodied. There isn’t the same fusion as in Ariel “how one we grow” “Set neat prints into the snow” – the snow resembles the blank page and the ‘prints’ are words Climactic moment remains symbolic – “with sudden sharp hot stink of fox/ it enters the dark hole of the head” Sharp’ – suggests something surgical about the way inspiration pierces his mind, contrasts with the earlier softness of snow imagery. Sensory vividness or intellectual acuity? ‘Stink’ signals that poetry originates in what civilisation represses – instinct, animality, the unconscious. Hughes aligns creativity with evolutionary impulse and raw
---	--	--

	confessional poetry – creativity is not symbolic play but existential exposure “Into the red/Eye, the cauldron of morning” Violent imagery suggests both rebirth and combustion. The poem enacts transformation but the cost is severe. Creativity is ecstatic it dangerous. Rosenthal claimed the confessionalism (in Robert Lowell) ‘Removes the mask’ that previous poets had worn when writing about their own lives. In an era of Cold War ‘containment’ culture and intense legal debates over prince, confessional poets carved out new zones for private life and experience – world in which you are judged for your thoughts and feelings, confessionalists find a way to express this through poetry	animality rather than divine inspiration Where Plath’s drive borders on ‘suicidal’, Hughes’ is organic and life-affirming “The page Is printed” – calm, declarative closure. The creative act is completed without the same kind of exposure of confessionalism
Personal experience/ confessionalism	‘Daddy’ Daddy represents confessional poetry at its most raw and confrontational. The personal experience is explicitly traumatic. Even when we call her confessional, she is always creating a mythology” – Susan Schultz “Daddy, I have had to kill you” - declarative bluntness is shocking, monosyllabic violence of ‘kill’ strips away poetic mediation Directly addresses the father, frames the poem as confrontation, blurs fantasy and autobiography Because Plath’s father died when she was 8, the killing cannot be literal. The confession is emotional truth	‘Full moon and little Frieda’ In contrast, Hughes’ poem expresses personal experience not through confessionalism but wonder and shared joy, yet he still retains symbolic distance Celebration of childhood innocence and wonder The setting is intimate “Cool small evening” - metaphorical smallness shows how ordinary of a night it is and therefore sets the stage for how children find beauty and awe in the simple and ordinary and therefore elicit the same reaction in their watching parents. The metaphors of blood and milk recall birth and

rather than factual reality – demonstrating how confessional poetry prioritises psychological authenticity over realism

“Chuffing me off like a Jew. A Jew to dauchau, auschwitz, Belsen” – references specific holocaust concentration camps. The personal is dramatised through historical horror. The confessional mode here is theatrical – private pain expressed through hyperbolic imagery

“I have always been scared of you/ with your Luftwaffe, your gobbledygoo”

The striking simplicity of ‘always been scared’ is childlike, conveying genuine fear
 Yet the juxtaposition of luftwaffe and nonsense baby language destabilises tone
 nursery rhyme rhythm creates disturbing tonal dissonance. Childish cadence contrasts with violent content

This tonal oscillation is key to the poem's confessionalist – the adult speaker recalls childhood terror, childish diction suggests regression
 Psychologically fragmented rather than composed or reflective

“Every woman adores a Fascist, the boot in the face, the brute/ brute heart of a brute like you”

Sweeping generalisation, suggesting internalised attraction to dominance
 Violent image is visceral and degrading

babyhood, “unspilled milk” suggests tension and potential, mimicking the potential a young child has, to experience the world for the first time.

“Moon! Moon” - sudden exclamation breaks the tension and shows how just like the moon, Frieda is an everyday miracle and her excitement at seeing it in turn awakens Hughes to both wonders.

Her urgent repetition conveys her awe through the toddler-like speech. (MOON SYMBOLISM)

Image of moon as “an artist” stepping back and “gazing amazed” creates a sense of awe and wonder reflecting back and forth between Frieda, the moon, and also Hughes.

The diacope of “amazed” underscores the mutual surprise and delight.

The artist moon becomes an image of Hughes himself, as he created Frieda, amazed at his daughter's own amazement and existence.

Aesthetic reflection. Unlike Plath's unmediated confession, Hughes uses metaphor to universalise the experience.
 Expresses indirectly through symbol and landscape”

	Repetition mimics pounding aggression Aligns with her marriage to Hughes – transference of paternal trauma onto husband figures “At twenty I tried to die/ and get back, back, back to you” Most overt autobiographical moment, referencing Plath’s suicide attempt Repetition mimics desperation, monosyllables create rhythmic urgency, also something childlike Exposes her reality without metaphorical disguise – removes the mask “Daddy, daddy, you bastard, i’m through” Repetition of daddy is childlike but bastard is adult rage Blunt monosyllables of ‘I’m through; delivers catharsis, finality Poem ends in confrontation. No reconciliation – only violent emotional closure ‘What had changed’ in these decades according to Christopher Grobe ‘more than art, was the audience’s desire. They wanted to know... their poets and politicians, their actors and news anchors too’ Plath and Hughes not directly showing us their emotions, expressing them through symbols (nazi imagery etc) – “objective correlative” coined by TS Eliot (modernist)	
Power – voice that claims supreme	‘mirror’ Patriarchal surveillance and reflective authority Power is expressed through surveillance, judgement	‘Hawk roosting’ Hawk roosting presents power as active, unapologetic sovereignty

authority	and the internalisation of patriarchal standards Passive yet absolute The mirror claims objective neutrality, yet its authority is absolute “I am silver and exact. I have no preconceptions” – declarative tone establishes epistemological dominance. Mirror positions itself as the arbiter of truth ‘Exact’ implies mathematical precision – unchallengeable The first person voice immediately claims authority over perception - “Locating the centre of consciousness in the mirror isolates the woman” – van dyne – makes the woman an object of scrutiny rather than subject “I am not cruel, only truthful – the eye of a little god” Mirror assumes divine omniscience. The eye suggests surveillance, a single, unblinking gaze Power here is visual and disciplinary. The woman cannot escape scrutiny. The mirror offers no consolation, only ‘the truth’ (distorted by internalised patriarchal beliefs) “A woman bends over me, searching my reaches for what she really is” – bend suggests submission, the woman is physically lowered before the mirror’s (now in the form of a lake) authority She depends on it for definition – identity is mediated through external judgment The dynamic reflects patriarchal structures – worth tied to appearance, value measured through external gaze “In me she has drowned a young girl, and in me an old	“I sit at the top of the wood, my eyes closed” Unlike Plath’s surveillance mirror, the hawk does not need to see to maintain power. His position symbolises hierarchy and supremacy. “It took the whole of Creation to produce my foot, my each feather.” - divine right to kill, natural, ‘Creation’ is capitalised alluding to the Christian creation myth, hawk has a mandate from God as a predator to kill Unlike the mirrors modest ‘little gods the hawk implies cosmic centrality - sees himself as the pinnacle of the evolutionary process. Darwinism, Tennyson’s ‘red in tooth and claw’ “Now I hold creation in my foot” – possession, control, Monosyllabic force makes the claim sounds unshakeable Voice is unapologetic – “My manners are tearing off heads” Power here is instinctive, unquestioned Irrelevance of human moral frameworks Chilling certainty: “nothing has changed since I began. My eye has permitted no change” Unlike the mirror, which passively reflects, the hawk is active His eye is not surveillance but control He governs reality
------------------	---	--

	woman rises ... like a terrible fish” – implies that ageing is monstrous. Bathetic, grotesque.	Voice is confident, stable, dominant “Pushing of the sublime into the brutal” – John Kinsella
Disturbing/ taboo/ offensive	‘Daddy’ Uses collective trauma for personal experience Disturbance lies in excess – emotional, rhetorical, historical “An engine, an engine/ chuffing me off like a Jew” – childish repetition contrasts grotesquely with the historical horror that follows “A Jew to Dachau, Auschwitz, Belsen” – specificity of the camps grounds the poem in historical atrocity. The shock lies in disproportion: personal grief is equated with genocide. Risks trivialisation, making the poem morally provocative “Not God but a swastika” – father becomes a fascist symbol, swastika replaces divinity – political terror supplants religious authority “Every woman adores a fascist/ the boot in the face” – Plath implicates not just herself but ‘every woman’ The violent image is humiliating and degrading The repetition of brute mimics pounding aggression Fashion for artistic depictions of violence following war, influenced by artworks like Picasso’s ‘Guernica’ which plainly and brutally expresses war’s violence. George Steiner asserts that Plath’s poem is the ‘Guernica of modern poetry’ Plath and Hughes not directly showing us their emotions, expressing them through symbols (nazi	‘View of a pig’ Disturbing due to its unflinching, stark description of a dead pig rather than appropriation Bluntness: “It was too dead” – death is not poeticised, it is heavy, inert, stubborn Describes the body with stark realism – “its weight oppressed me” Suggests moral as well as physical burden “Such weight and thick pink bulk” – pig becomes disturbingly close to human corporeality. Hughes refuses to distance the reader through pastoral or symbolic language. Rhythm is heavy, repeated plosives mimic the physical heaviness “Just so much a poundage of lard and pork” – dismissive phrase, economic tone, calculated, transactional – no longer an animal but a commodity Death erases individuality, the body becomes a product Processed, consumable forms of flesh – pig is already linguistically butchered Unlike Plath’s symbolic violence, Hughes’ disturbance is material “It was like a sack of wheat” Simile reduces the animal to agricultural mass. No sentimental gloss. Death is ordinary and industrial.

	imagery etc) – “objective correlative” coined by TS Eliot (modernist)	The shock lies in refusal of consolation The pig is not aestheticised, redeemed or transcended, it is simply flesh Hyperbolic metaphor vs refusal of metaphor “Pushing of the sublime into the brutal” – John Kinsella
Insight into human nature	‘Mirror’ Plath offers a bleak insight into the human condition: identity is fragile, externally mediated and deeply entangled with patriarchal beliefs “I am silver and exact. I have no preconceptions” – mirror claims neutrality, yet this supposed objectivity becomes tyrannical Humans long for reassurance but the mirror provides only fact The insight here is uncomfortable: truth is indifferent to emotional need “Locating the centre of consciousness in the mirror isolates the woman.” – Van Dyne – the woman doesn’t control the narrative, she must search externally for identity “Whatever I see I swallow immediately” No pause, no mercy. Human life is consumed moment by moment. Mirror becomes a symbol of temporal inevitability “A woman bends over me, searching my reaches for what she really is” Searching suggests existential anxiety The woman seeks identity in reflection rather than	‘Thought fox’ “I imagine this midnight moment’s forest” – forest represents subconscious – dense, dark, unknowable Hughes suggests that creativity emerges from hidden depths of the mind The fox appears gradually: “a fox’s nose touches twig, leaf” – delicate monosyllables mimic tentative thought. Inspiration is subtle at first – exploratory rather than explosive “Set neat prints into the snow” – snow symbolises the blank page, the prints symbolise words Hughes insightfully captures how ideas leave traces before fully forming Creativity is incremental Climactic moment: “With a sudden sharp hot stink of fox it enters the dark hole of the head” – the visceral ‘stink’ emphasises instinct and animal vitality Creativity is not purely intellectual – it is bodily, primal – rejects divine inspiration The dark hole suggests the unconscious mind Sharp’ – suggests something surgical about the way

	within herself Plath exposes a universal human impulse: to define oneself through external image Recalls Lacanian theories of identity formation and the 'mirror stage' in which the self is constructed and destabilised through external image "In me she has drowned a young girl ... like a terrible fish" Grotesque, bathetic simile reveals how ageing can feel monstrous under scrutiny Denies beauty or serenity – ageing is elite and frightening 'Day after day' repetition reinforces inevitability Crucially, this insight is gendered. The woman's obsession reflects societal pressure, yet the poem suggests that the most relentless judge is internalised Second wave feminism emerging in the early 1960s. Women increasingly critiquing beauty standards, domestic roles, objectification Mirror is symbolic of patriarchal surveillance	inspiration pierces his mind, contrasts with the earlier softness of snow imagery. Sensory vividness or intellectual acuity Hughes believed poetry should reconnect modern humanity with instinct and the unconscious – influenced by DH Lawrence – fox can be read as the manifestation of instinct, a creative force beyond rationality Writing in post ww2 Britain marked by rationalism and cultural exhaustion, his poetry turns towards primal instinct and animal vitality "The page is printed" – calm declarative closure
Creative process	'words' Plath studies what happens once words exit Written 10 days before Plath took her life Opens with poetic creation as an act of violence and rupture: "Axes/ After whose stroke the wood rings" Act of writing is figured as a blow; the stroke of the pen becomes the stroke of an axe Sarah Churchwell: "Aggressive possibilities of language"	'Thought-fox' Hughes studies the genesis of poetry – ars poetica Hughes begins from almost total stillness rather than Plath's force and violence, suggesting a radically different origin for creativity "I imagine this midnight moment's forest" – consciousness, natural also used as a metaphor for the creative process

– words are not gentle tools of expression but weapons
Lacuna after ‘axe’ leaves sense of acoustic hollowness,
allowing space for the words to echo

“Wood rings” evoke age, dynasty – the concentric
memory of the tree resembles the layers of literary
tradition - poem acknowledges its own stance, reveals
its predecessors

Yet Plath’s axe cuts those rings – Even in Yeats’ former
house she stages creation as rebellion against inherited
forms while acknowledging her indebtedness to them

After the initial strike, Plath’s words cease to belong to
the speaker: “Echoes travelling off from the centre like
horses”

Poem becomes centrifugal; language splinters outward
from its point of origin in sporadic, uncontrolled
movement

Christina Britzolakis: Words “ultimately escaping the
speaker’s control”

Trochee creates echoing effect ‘axes’ ‘echoes’
Relocates the horse from Ariel as a wild bolting creature
rather than a vehicle for self-liberation

“Sap wells like tears, like the water striving to
reestablish its mirror over the rock” – sap, ostensibly
life-giving, runs from a wound and becomes conflated
with tears

The water strains to become a reflective surface that
can claim accurate representation
Plathian image reveals that words are an imitation of

Creativity is gradual visitation rather than a violent
strike

Inspiration appears tentatively – “a fox’s nose touches
twig, leaf”

Careful monosyllables mimic delicate emergence.
Creativity is incremental, not explosive.

“Through the window I see no star” – pointedly refuses
the conventional celestial emblem of poetic guidance.
There is no romantic muse, divine inspiration,
transcendental literary lineage. Statement against
literary tradition, relocates inspiration within the
earthly and animal rather than some higher force

The fox enters from the margins of darkness and moves
steadily inward. Instead of echoes travelling away from
the centre, Hughes’ thought concentrates into distinct
form. **Creativity is still not fully willed, but it is
directional rather than dispersive.**

“Widening deepening greenness” -dactylic, sense of
fading and decreasing, fertile unconscious from which
the poem emerges

Hughes’ fox is never riderless or anarchic: it leaves
“neat prints” in the snow.

“with sudden sharp hot stink of fox/ it enters the dark
hole of the head”

Sharp’ – suggests something surgical about the way
inspiration pierces his mind, contrasts with the earlier
softness of snow imagery. Sensory vividness or

life rather than a form of life itself, language fails
Poem itself feels liquid, concave and convex,
transforming similes in a seamless way

“Riderless” “Dry” horses, words lose their meaning
without the voice attached to them, dislocation between
person and words

Dissonance between the speaker when they wrote the
words and the speaker now

Confessionalism: Plath drawing on her own experiences
and emotions much like the confessionalists she is
believed to have taken inspiration from – Emily
Dickinson and Robert Lowell

“From the bottom of the pool, fixed stars govern a life” –
looking into the bottom of a pool and seeing the
reflection of the stars above us. Words claim objective
truth and reality

‘Govern’ – loss of autonomy, being governed by the
words she’s written and how other people interpret
them

It’s out of her control the minute she’s written it down
on the paper

FORM:

Plath’s regular quintains create a false shell of order
while semantic coherence steadily dissolves
Blank spaces, abrupt caesurae and the irregular swell
from monosyllables to polysyllables (‘indefatigable’)
enact what Steven Gould Axelrod calls the poem’s
struggle against “entropic forces”

intellectual acuity?

‘Stink’ signals that poetry originates in what civilisation
represses – instinct, animality, the unconscious. Hughes
aligns creativity with evolutionary impulse and raw
animality rather than divine inspiration

FORM:

The poem’s almost chiasmic movement inward and
outward, with the repeated “And now, and now” at its
centre, creates a cyclical atrocity

Hughes closes with the simple “The page is printed”.
Unlike Plath’s stars, which expose the insufficiency of
words, Hughes ends with successful embodiment: the
invisible movement of thought has left visible marks,

Personal vs universal experience	‘Cut’ Although triggered by a minor personal injury, Plath rapidly expands the poem into a meditation on the universal legacy of historic violence and the collective shame it produces The cut finger becomes a symbolic wound through which national and human brutality erupts “A flap like a hat” – unexpected, almost playful comparison creates discomfort by trivialising the wound, highlighting the banality of violence, an idea credited to Hannah Ardent in her book <i>The Banality of Evil</i> (1961) Re-emphasised in juvenile register of “Whose side are they on?” “Redcoats” and the American war for independence is seen as a thrilling game rather than a tragedy. Comments on how violence can become spectacle Like a childish audience watching a game – the way collective audiences turn historical warfare into binary entertainment Rhyme of “I am ill. I have taken a pill to kill” – gives impression of a kind of childish chant or nursery rhyme, how we underplay the significance of acts of violence. Similar effect with sing-song rhythm of “A million soldiers run, redcoats, every one.” Transforms a drop of blood into the entire history of the American War of Independence Deborah Nelson: “the poem explores the way war and violence become banal and morally ambiguous.”	‘Snowdrop’ Explores the universal struggle to survive “Now the globe shrunk tight/ Round the mouse’s dulled withering heart” – combination of micro and microcosmic imagery creates a sense of asphyxiation and contraction while the assonance gives the line a soporific quality Enjambment of the lines also subtly evokes the constriction as the first line seems to exert its grip around the following. Weasel and crow described as moving “as if moulded in brass” – animals’ movements appear heavy and stiff from the cold Use of manmade imagery when describing nature creates a sense of the industrial brutality of winter. “She too pursues her ends” – exposes ultimately hopeful attitude of the poem Due to the snowdrop’s ability to adapt, it makes it out and survives the harshness of winter in the end. ‘Too’ places the flower in the same universal struggle as the other animals in the poems: all life is engaged in relentless survival “Her pale head hangs heavy as metal” – encapsulates how violence engenders more violence in the natural world. It is this quality of nature, its resilience and ability to survive against all odds, that makes it so powerful. Winter in the poem is not sentimentalised as picturesque; it is a testing ground in which living things become harsher in order to persist
---	--	---

“Your turkey wattle” interwoven with extremely violent images “The Indian’s axed your scalp” – relates brutality to an image of Thanksgiving and celebration, directly criticising his historic American violence is honoured in the name of patriotism rather than being recognised for the devastation it was.

The loaded image of “The stain on your gauze Klu Klux Klan” – refers to the white hoods of white supremacist organisation founded in 1865. Image would’ve been especially associated with a very present violence for readers as, at the time Plath was writing, the third clan was opposing the civil rights movement in the 60s and committing savage racist attacks.

The image of the gauze creates the sense of an attempt to mask and hide the violence but the blood shows through anyways.

Combined with the poem’s historic references moving from past present creates the idea that the guilt and shame of American violence is generational and ignoring it or worse, celebrating it, only allows it to continue.

Deborah Nelson: “dissociates the speaker from the injury” allowing the poem to “explore the anaesthetising effects of spectatorship.” – perhaps the poem is intentionally distant to show how ignorance and dismissiveness towards the violence in our history can facilitate further violence and being a spectator can desensitise us to the tragedy.

“Dirty girl” – speaker ends not with pain but with

Universal biological truth

BOTH POEMS begin with seemingly small focal points (cut thumb, snowdrop) but expand outward into universal experiences larger than the individual speaker

Both suggest that violence is cyclical and self-perpetuating

Plath’s conclusion is contaminated and guilty whereas Hughes’ is admiring and hopeful

Hughes reaction against the movement poets (everyday life; lyric in simple language) “Dramatic departure from the prevailing modes of the period” Shaw

Hughes rejects the movements underlying belief that poetry should emerge from civilised consciousness

The creative process is irrational rather than intellectual

The language is sensuous and incantatory rather than plain-speaking

	shame and contamination. Dirty implies moral pollution. She wants to cleanse herself and purge herself of the guilt and in a way, this is exactly what the poem is meant to be for the speaker, an act of catharsis. Exposes a universal tendency to watch, narrativise and therefore normalise violence until shame finally breaks through	
--	--	--

Sylvia Plath and Ted Hughes both explore the theme of ____ in their poetry, presenting it as both ____ yet _____. Hughes' depictions often draw on his romantic predecessors such as Tennyson and Wordsworth, portraying _____ as a fact of life that is both _____ and _____ seen in his poems _____ and _____. In contrast, Plath depicts _____ as _____, drawing on her own experiences and emotions much like the confessionalists she is believed to have taken inspiration from – Emily Dickinson and Robert Lowell. This is evident in her poems ____ and _____. Therefore...